Politics FHS 2021-2022
Internal Examiners' Report

Desmond King.
Politics FHS convener/Politics Subject Board chair 2021-22

Administration.
The Politics part of PPE and HP FHS reverted to in person examinations in Schools (as did Philosophy, History but not Economics which retained an online format). This decision permitted a reversion to previous practices, with the caveat that many candidates had MCEs and special circumstances which had to be accommodated.

The whole Politics FHS examination process was superbly orchestrated by Durga Sapre; without Durga the process would have been much less efficacious. The board also drew upon many colleagues who kindly agreed to act as paper assessors; this included DLs and a swathe of post-doctoral fellows in the Department and colleges. Many assessors contributed also to question-setting.

Some candidates had special arrangements for sitting the examinations, usually a room arranged in their colleges, and in some cases permission was given for online completion with the usual time allowance.

Classification rules.
Classification was based on the mean score of 8 submitted papers for PPE and 7 for HP ranked across all candidates. The main PPE/HP FHS Examiners' report give the breakdown across classes awarded, and by gender. It was noted that in PPE the top set of Firsts were achieved by candidates with mainly Economics papers. There was a large number of MCEs to review (though not as great as last year) and many of these petitions resulted in different rankings within final class of degree and in a small number of cases across class classification (eg from 2.i to 1).

Academic practice.
There were no cases of plagiarism. One or two cases were investigated for theses using Turnitin but plagiarism was not identified.

The FHS Politics examiners carefully reviewed the distribution of marks for each paper, scrutinizing the range of marks between first and second assessors and reconciliations. Median marks were reviewed against patterns last year and in the pre-pandemic years. Unlike previous years the examiners did not need to modify any paper's distribution of marks. There were no assessor effects, a common pattern in previous year's markings.

The examiners are grateful to Nicholas James for producing clear and helpful statistical analyses of the patterns of marks distribution in several formats. Theses spreadsheets enabled the examiners to carefully review the marks on all Politics papers.

The external examiner reviewed a sample of scripts from various papers. She was not asked to adjudicate on marks. Adjudication did require the use of 3rd markers in a relatively small number of cases. The external examiner was asked to read to adjudicate on a number of scripts in the HPol board since that is the practice in History. The external examiner helpfully read and marked several scripts during the days of the Board meetings.

Politics FHS 2022 - exam performance statistics by paper and school

	School	Takeup	Mean	St. Dev	Max	Min	>=70	>=60	>=50	>=40	Lower Q	Median	Upper Q
Total	PPE	1472	66.4	4.93	81	30	26.30%	66%	6.93%	0.41%	64	67	70
	HP	290	67.4	4.13	80	55	30.30%	66.20%	3.45%	0%	65	67	70
	Combined	1762	66.6	4.82	81	30	27.00%	66.10%	6.36%	0.34%	64	67	70
Advanced Paper in Theories of Justice	PPE	19	66.9	6.05	74	48	31.60%	63.20%	0%	5%	65.5	68	70.5
	HP	2	68.5	0.707	69	68	0%	100%	0%	0%	68.2	68.5	68.8
	Combined	21	67.1	5.76	74	48	29%	67%	0%	5%	66	68	70
British Politics and Government since 1900	PPE	56	65.3	8.01	81	40	26.80%	53.60%	16.10%	3.57%	61	66.5	70
	HP	13	64.9	5.09	74	55	15.40%	69.20%	15%	0%	63	65	68
	Combined	69	65.2	7.52	81	40	25%	56.50%	15.90%	2.90%	61	66	69
Comparative Demographic Systems	PPE	3	72	1.73	74	71	100%	0%	0%	0%	71	71	72.5
	HP	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
	Combined	3	72	1.73	74	71	100%	0%	0%	0%	71	71	72.5
Comparative Government	PPE	61	65.3	6.49	78	30	21.30%	70.50%	6.56%	0%	63	65	68
	HP	6	70.7	5.68	80	63	50.00%	50.00%	0.00%	0%	68.2	70	72.5
	Combined	67	65.8	6.56	80	30	24%	68.70%	5.97%	0%	63	65	69
Comparative Political Economy	PPE	35	67.1	3.3	73	60	25.70%	74.30%	0%	0%	65	67	69.5
	HP	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
	Combined	35	67.1	3.3	73	60	25.70%	74.30%	0%	0%	65	67	69.5
Government and Politics of the United States	PPE	13	66.4	3.5	71	59	30.80%	61.50%	7.69%	0%	65	66	70
	HP	2	69.5	3.54	72	67	50.00%	50.00%	0%	0%	68.2	69.5	70.8
	Combined	15	66.8	3.55	72	59	33.30%	60.00%	6.67%	0%	65	67	70
International Relations	PPE	121	66.3	4.5	79	53	24.80%	68.60%	6.61%	0%	64	66	69
	HP	27	67.2	4.1	74	60	33%	67%	0%	0%	64.5	66	70.5
	Combined	148	66.4	4.43	79	53	26.40%	68.20%	5.41%	0%	64	66	70
International Relations in the Era of Two World Wars	PPE	4	66	5.1	71	59	25.00%	50.00%	25%	0%	64.2	67	68.8
	HP	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
	Combined	4	66	5.1	71	59	25.00%	50.00%	25%	0%	64.2	67	68.8
International Relations in the Era of the Cold War	PPE	19	65.9	5.04	76	58	26.30%	68.40%	5.26%	0%	62	67	69
	HP	3	69	5.2	75	66	33.30%	66.70%	0%	0%	66	66	70.5
	Combined	22	66.3	5.06	76	58	27.30%	68.20%	4.55%	0%	64	66.5	69.5
Marx and Marxism	PPE	20	67.5	4.84	76	59	30.00%	65.00%	5%	0%	64.5	67.5	71
	HP	3	65.3	4.62	68	60	0%	100%	0%	0%	64	68	68
	Combined	23	67.2	4.76	76	59	26.10%	69.60%	4%	0%	64	68	70
Modern British Government and Politics	PPE	19	65.9	2.81	72	62	15.80%	84.20%	0.00%	0%	64	65	68
	HP	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
	Combined	19	65.9	2.81	72	62	15.80%	84.20%	0.00%	0%	64	65	68
Political Sociology	PPE	72	65.7	5.06	78	55	22.20%	63.90%	13.90%	0.00%	63	66	69
	HP	21	66.8	4	79	58	19%	76%	5%	0%	65	66	68
	Combined	93	65.9	4.85	79	55	21.50%	66.70%	11.80%	0.00%	63	66	69
Political Thought: Bentham to Weber	PPE	10	68.6	3.34	75	63	20.00%	80.00%	0%	0%	68	68	68.8
	HP	1	73	-	73	73	100.00%	0.00%	0%	0%	73	73	73
	Combined	11	69	3.44	75	63	27.30%	72.70%	0%	0%	68	68	71

no candidates in the bands 30-40 and <30, except Comparative Government where combined 1.49% in the band 30-40

Politics FHS 2022 - exam performance statistics by paper and school

	School	Takeup	Mean	St. Dev	Max	Min	>=70	>=60	>=50	>=40	Lower Q	Median	Upper Q
Political Thought: Plato to Rousseau	PPE	12	67.3	4.27	76	61	16.70%	83.30%	0.00%	0%	64.8	67	68.2
	HP	3	71	3.61	75	68	66.70%	33.30%	0%	0%	69	70	72.5
	Combined	15	68.1	4.3	76	61	27%	73.30%	0.00%	0%	65.5	68	69.5
Politics in China	PPE	18	65.1	4.09	71	56	27.80%	66.70%	5.56%	0%	62.2	65	69
	HP	4	68.8	5.06	73	63	50%	50%	0%	0%	65.2	69.5	73
	Combined	22	65.7	4.4	73	56	31.80%	63.60%	4.55%	0%	63	65.5	70
Politics in Europe	PPE	4	67.8	3.3	71	64	50.00%	50.00%	0%	0%	65.5	68	70.2
	HP	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
	Combined	4	67.8	3.3	71	64	50%	50%	0%	0%	65.5	68	70.2
Politics in Latin America	PPE	12	65.2	2.82	70	58	8.33%	83.30%	8.33%	0%	64	65.5	66.2
	HP	4	67.8	3.77	73	65	0.25	0.75	0	0	65	66.5	69.2
	Combined	16	65.8	3.17	73	58	12.50%	81.20%	6.25%	0%	64.8	65.5	67
Politics in Russia and the Former Soviet Union	PPE	8	69	3.16	73	65	50.00%	50.00%	0%	0%	66	69	72
	HP	3	65.7	1.53	67	64	0%	100%	0%	0%	65	66	66.5
	Combined	11	68.1	3.14	73	64	36.40%	63.60%	0%	0%	66	67	71
Politics in South Asia	PPE	4	67.5	2.08	70	65	25.00%	75.00%	0%	0%	66.5	67.5	68.5
	HP	2	71	0	71	71	100%	0%	0%	0%	71	71	71
	Combined	6	68.7	2.42	71	65	50%	50%	0%	0%	67.2	69	70.8
Politics in Sub-Saharan Africa	PPE	14	67.7	2.33	71	64	36%	64%	0%	0%	66.2	67	70
	HP	5	69.4	4.56	77	66	0.4	0.6	0	0	66	68	70
	Combined	19	68.2	3.02	77	64	37%	63%	0%	0%	66	67	70
Politics in the Middle East	PPE	32	67.2	3.39	73	58	34.40%	62.50%	3.12%	0%	65	68	70
	HP	13	67.2	2.91	71	60	15%	85%	0%	0%	67	68	69
	Combined	45	67.2	3.23	73	58	28.90%	68.90%	2.22%	0%	65	68	70
Special Subject: Feminist Theory	PPE	12	69.5	3.29	76	65	50%	50%	0%	0%	67.8	69.5	70.8
	HP	7	67	2.16	71	64	14%	86%	0%	0%	66	67	67.5
	Combined	19	68.6	3.11	76	64	36.80%	63.20%	0.00%	0%	66.5	68	70
Special Subject: International Security & Conflict	PPE	45	66.7	3.5	77	58	17.80%	77.80%	4.44%	0%	65	66	68
	HP	4	69.5	2.08	72	67	50.00%	50.00%	0.00%	0%	68.5	69.5	70.5
	Combined	49	66.9	3.48	77	58	20.40%	75.50%	4.08%	0%	65	67	68
Social Policy	PPE	25	64.5	4.47	76	58	16.00%	72.00%	12.00%	0%	61	64	67
	HP	8	66.5	5.32	70	58	50.00%	25.00%	25.00%	0%	65.5	69	70
	Combined	33	65	4.68	76	58	24.20%	60.60%	15.20%	0%	61	65	69
Sociological Theory	PPE	7	68.3	2.98	73	64	28.60%	71.40%	0.00%	0%	67	67	70
	HP	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
	Combined	7	68.3	2.98	73	64	29%	71%	0%	0%	67	67	70
The Politics of the European Union	PPE	7	70.6	3.31	75	65	71%	29%	0%	0%	69	71	72.5
	HP	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
	Combined	7	70.6	3.31	75	65	71.40%	28.60%	0.00%	0%	69	71	72.5
Theory of Politics	PPE	84	66.8	4.69	77	57	29.80%	60.70%	10%	0%	64	67	70
	HP	19	66.9	4.2	74	58	42.10%	52.60%	5.26%	0%	64	67	70
	Combined	103	66.8	4.59	77	57	32%	59%	9%	0%	64	67	70
Thesis in Politics	PPE	13	70.2	4.59	78	62	69%	31%	0%	0%	69	70	73
	HP	5	65.2	6.69	73	56	40.00%	40.00%	20.00%	0%	62	65	70
	Combined	18	68.8	5.54	78	56	61.10%	33.30%	5.56%	0%	65	70	73

no candidates in the bands 30-40 and <30

Thesis in Politics

18 students submitted Politics thesis in Trinity 2022.
Thesis titles are listed below.

1. Platonic Justice as a Relational Virtue - The Importance of Fraternity in Plato's Republic
2. China's perception of hierarchy and status in international order - A historical approach to understanding the role of stigma and status dissatisfaction in Chinese foreign policy.
3. Political Actors Operating under Uncertainty: The Case of the Portuguese Transition to Democracy between 1974 and 1976
4. Populism-as-Consumption: Politics Through the Eyes of Bataille's General Economy
5. How Does Regime Type Affects the Timing and Stringency of Countries' Early-stage Responses to the COVID-19 Pandemic?
6. Corrupt representatives do not affect political trust. The case of the 2009 British parliamentary expenses scandal.
7. Immigration Attitudes and Support for Radical Left Parties in Europe
8. ON THE BORDERS OF DEMOCRACY - The Case for Denizen Enfranchisement
9. Up Schmitt's Creek: The Communist Party of China's political evolution towards Carl Schmitt and its effects on Hong Kong
10. 'War of Words' in the Persian Gulf? An Evaluation of the Utility of Feminist Security Theories.
11. Islam and the Algerian Revolution: A Thesis on the Impact of Islam on the Algerian Revolution
12. Cognitive Immobilisation? Exploring the impact of information on individual-level electoral volatility.
13. Changing the Rules of Autocracy: The Politics of Electoral Reform in Competitive Authoritarian Ukraine
14. The Effect of Compulsory Voting on Elite Polarisation: A Quasi-Natural Experiment in Austria
15. You are what you tweet: the influence of social media on political identity in Hong Kong, 2009-2021.
16. Under Which Circumstances Does Asymmetric Demographic Change in Federal Systems Affect the Welfare State?
17. Leading Men: How early Soviet cinema sought to shape popular ideals of masculinity
18. How might a permanently neutral state credibly signal its neutral policy?

201 Comparative Government

No questions were reported during the exam and the overall quality of answers was high.

The unweighted average score across all questions was similar.

I now turn to comments from examiners on questions where specific errors were noted or questions where commendably strong answers were presented. The commentary of a question here (or lack thereof) has no bearing on whether the topic will appear on the next iteration of the exam.

Question 1. Answers should have discussed multiple theories for voter demands for parties and multiple reasons why parties might compete or proliferate. As is standard, exams should have presented a mix of quantitative and qualitative evidence from multiple regions (such as Europe, the US, the Latin America), citing Shugart, Samuels. Good answers defined precisely what a change in the party system meant and how to measure them.

Question 2. Good answers needed to put some analytical clarity on the prompt in terms of what might be a reasonable definition in the literature on "working" – such as improving voter welfare, improving the electoral prospects of parties, increasing electoral accountability, etc. Then answers proceeded to delineate different categories of "beneficiaries" drawing on empirical studies from regions, ideally beyond just Latin America (but good answers could be circumspect in their evidence of they acknowledged as such and justified this choice). Whether the answer was affirmative or not regarding the prompt was less relevant than whether multiple arguments about why a certain group would be a beneficiary was discussed. Subtle answers considered counter arguments – for example, if an inefficiency to clientelism was discussed, some consideration for why that inefficiency persisted was merited.

Question 5. Answers needed to engage Tilly, and some good answers referred to Bates and Spruyt in detail. Good answers defined first why we might expect war-making to help in state formation and then discussed factors such as civil war, international intervention, capital ratios, and examined and defined state-making conceptually. More subtle answers provided conditions for the prompt and incorporated evidence from Europe and outside of Europe.

9. Strong answers defined the scope of "long-run impact" and discussed both economic outcomes, democratic outcomes, or other outcomes, and further justified the choice. Good answers could consider either one of these categories of variables, but then the choice had to be justified and acknowledgement of other possible dependent variables was needed for a satisfactory mark. Engagement with Acemoglu, Robinson, and related readings was essential. Strong answers articulated multiple pathways by which geography would matter and articulated different examples and definitions of "colonial institutions." Strong answers considered multiple areas of former colonies.

Question 10. Stronger answers defined and justified the choices of federalism, and considered both civil-conflict/state formation as well as political economy consequences. Good answers could consider either one of these categories of variables, but then the choice had to be justified and acknowledgement of other possible dependent variables was needed for a satisfactory mark. The most analytically incisive answers sought to justify or critique

common institutions and features relevant for both sets of dependent variables. They indicated understanding of different institutional features of federalism or mechanisms.

11. Strong answers defined the scope of “political effects” and discussed potential variables either antecedent to or related to party-system fragmentation. These could include voter turnout, voter attitudes, incentives of new political parties, and political orientation of governments. Answers needed to articulate and interrogate the premise of the prompt which is that such electoral systems do in fact affect party system fragmentation (and whether that relationship is in fact theoretically and empirically defensible). Most subtle answers argued whether other effects of electoral systems are the result of similar mechanisms that might produce fragmentation (if that premise was accepted).

12. Good answers first listed the arguments linking mobilisation to democratic change and outlined what might be defined as structural factors (such as economic wealth or inequality or divisions within society). More subtle answers thought of a connection between these two sets of explanations, but high-achieving answers also chose one argument and gave multiple reasons why that reason was preferred. Excellent answers also considered the contingent nature of both sets of explanations, with attention to evidence from different regions of the world and time periods.

202 British Politics and Government Since 1900

There were 69 candidates for the paper; 56 in PPE and 13 in History and Politics.

The examiners were struck by the number of scripts containing two good answers and one weak answer. This seemed to be either because too few topics had been revised, or because knowledge was too obviously restricted to tutorial essays and no wider reading. It was therefore inflexible. It is also true, of course, that the best candidates produced thoughtful, clear and sometimes powerfully argued papers. Very few students wrote three weak answers.

Question 1: What did "socialism" mean to the Labour Party before 1939? (12 answers)

Candidates knew a great deal about "socialism" in Labour Party thought up to 1918, and about tactics involved in the 1918 constitution. A few knew about the revival of socialism under a younger generation of Labour economists and the publication of Labour's Immediate Programme in 1937. Some also argued that the 'class harmony' of MacDonald meant little to unions in the inter-war years of high unemployment, and therefore socialist ideas retreated in significance. Answers concentrated on years up to 1924 but were nevertheless good or very good.

Question 2: Did the Liberal Party before 1914 have anything to fear from the extension of the franchise? (23 answers)

Most candidates thought that the Liberals did have something to fear, although for a wide variety of reasons. The young Labour Party, industrial disputes, the impossibility of maintaining the voting coalition which had sustained the Liberals, demands of suffragettes, were all offered as reasons, as was the growth of 'class' in politics (in a rather general fashion). Curiosly, the Conservatives were rarely mentioned. Those who argued that Liberals had little to fear tried to refute the familiar arguments. The 'New Liberalism' had solidified support, the Liberals enjoyed generally good relations with trade unions and the Labour Party was still only capable of fighting a small number of constituencies at an election. The Liberals still championed progressive politics. Students were very good as marshalling material they needed for whatever they wanted to argue.

Question 3: Did the passing of self-government for Ireland in 1921-1922 mark the success or failure of Westminster government? (6 answers)

Of the small number of answers, all but one were self-confident and detailed. They concluded in roughly equal proportions that it marked 'success' or 'failure'. A few linked the legislation to domestic politics: "Lloyd George took advantage of Conservative divisions" according to one candidate. There were also interesting comments about how the war had split Irish Nationalism but united Ulster Unionism. Strikingly, essays displayed knowledge of authors. Three or four of the essays were clearly first class.

Question 4: Why was women's suffrage so divisive at Westminster before 1918? (23 answers)

Some answers were subtle, knew important relevant events, and particularly the changing political landscape within which the arguments evolved. Other answers were too blunt and lacked analysis. They simply stated that the issue was largely settled by 1900, the suffragettes

were brave but repelled MPs, the House of Commons was reactionary, and Asquith was implacably opposed to women's enfranchisement. These essays also omitted the war altogether. They were unconvincing answers and would probably have been written whatever the question. Good answers discussed divisions within both of the main parties, and the reasons for them – including religion, education and property. They also recognised that women's suffrage was part of a larger movement towards democracy – including enfranchising about four million men. The war caused the collapse of opposition to democracy, and the best essays explored this eloquently.

Question 5: "Conservative government in all but name". Discuss with reference to EITHER a) the National Governments of 1931-1940 (no answers) OR b) the Coalition Government of 2010-2015 (only one answer)

Question 6: Why was the Attlee government so much more successful than the first two Labour governments? (24 answers)

Nearly all answers came from candidates who had studied the Attlee governments, but who often knew little about the first two Labour administrations. There were obvious reasons for greater success in 1945; Labour's experience of government during the war and the coherent proposals in Let Us Face the Future. Candidates knew less about Labour's achievements, although some questioned the word 'successful' in the title. In particular, most knew little about what nationalisation was intended to do, and nothing about relations with the USA, whether financial or military. Labour's legislation was expensive, especially the Beveridge proposals, although the reader would not have guessed it from most essays. A few good essays made a link between full employment after 1945, high unemployment in 1929-1931, and the changing beliefs about what governments could do to attack unemployment. The candidates had usually studied (or at least read about) the earlier Labour governments and made use of their knowledge. The importance of inter-war issues, like Free Trade and the gold standard, and their disappearance by 1945, was also commented on. But the question asked implicitly about lack of success of the first two governments (the crash in 1931, for example). The best essays were impressive and broad. But the weakest made only passing reference to anything before 1945 and guessed wildly about dates of the first two Labour governments, including even to the extent that the second Labour government survived until 1940 and took the country to war. Such candidates would have been well-advised to look elsewhere for their third answer.

Question 7: Was decolonisation part of consensus politics? (7 answers)

Only a few answers, dividing nearly equally between agreement and disagreement with the question. The essays were nearly all of a high standard, showing knowledge about both consensus and the process of decolonisation. The best managed to marry together economic factors, rising nationalism, pressure from the USA, and the position in domestic politics – interesting to read, and persuasive.

Question 8: Why did relations between Labour governments and trade unions become so conflictual in the 1970s? (4 answers)

Too few answers from which to draw many conclusions. But all except one answer suffered from the same weakness. There was a tendency to see 'government' and 'trade unions' as monolithic and unchanging. In fact, trade unions were a complex mosaic, often competing

against each other. They were unsuited for the political conflict of the 1970s – of which they were only a part. Some of the Labour Party had been radicalised after the 1970 election defeat, and the parliamentary party was increasingly difficult to lead.

Question 9: Why did the Conservative government of 1979-1997 achieve so much in the 1980s, but so little in the 1990s? (48 answers)

A question which caused sharp differences of opinion. Most candidates accepted the assumption of the title (a few without discussion, which was disappointing). Nearly all candidates knew something of the 1990s, though some ignored the decade and made no mention of John Major. Some essays were excellent, and a few of these argued against the title from ideological, economic or some other ground. A very few bold candidates picked out themes and ran with them over the whole period – Europe and economic policy were usually selected. They concluded that divisions between the decades were less important than the question supposed. Knowledge of authors and some evidence of what an author wrote was frequent and put to good use. But simply listing authors and scattering them around was unhelpful, especially when authors' names were attached to basic factual errors. Similarly, very weak students produced a trail of wrong dates, elections in years when there was no election, the Maastricht Treaty being approved anywhere between 1987 and 1996 – or in one case being passed by Labour. Such crude mistakes can only hurt candidates. But these scripts were far outnumbered by those which were clear, accurate and well-argued.

Question 10: Did the birth of New Labour mark the death of class politics? (50 answers)

Some candidates were uncertain how they wanted to treat 'class politics' and fell back onto Labour support amongst the 'working class' (itself unidentified). Some began more crisply by arguing that the internal changes to the party structure dropped a commitment to socialism which had not been pursued in office anyway. And most noted that trade unions were much diminished in numbers and influence (which, according to some, suited New Labour). Most argued that New Labour was a programme for government and for keeping Blair and Brown in office. A few essays looked in detail at the 'birth' of New Labour and used snatches of later information only sparingly, whist others made statements about 1994-1997, and then linked them to legislation which followed. A few (unwisely) took a chronological approach and ran out of things to say (and time). Shaw's argument about sacrificing 'Labour's soul' were popular, although the consequences of the arguments were rarely considered. The 'third way' got short shrift, especially from candidates who were evidently good economists. Many argued that criticisms of Labour for 'abandoning' the working class were misplaced. Labour embraced globalisation because it produced economic growth, which in turn allowed Labour to help the poorest. When growth ran out, so did Labour's progressive legislation. A few, weak, candidates had apparently never heard of Brown as prime minister, or the recession. (Their essays petered out in about 2005). A frequent and well-argued conclusion was that 'class politics' survived New Labour, but that it involved groups including immigrants, the worst paid non-unionised, and the poorest pensioners. Many answers to this question were very good, interesting to read, and perceptive.

Question 11: "Since 1997, Scottish politics and government have so diverged from the politics and government of the rest of the UK that they are better studied as the politics and government of an independent country." Do you agree? (no answers)

Question 12: Did the Brexit referendum of 2016 concern only membership of the EU? (4 answers)

Too few answers from which to draw conclusions, except that three answers were well informed, all arguing that immigration and nationalism were both important.

203 Theory of Politics

NB: This paper can be taken as both a Politics and a Philosophy paper, and the answer counts below include both sets of candidates.

1. Can a political theory be both normative and realistic? (12 answers)
The challenge of this question was to connect the debates concerning 'realism' and 'moralism' in political theory, ideal vs. non-ideal theory, and/or feasibility to the specific question regarding the suggested tension between a theory being 'normative' and 'realistic'. Better answers identified and discussed this tension, rather than simply reproducing debates in the literature.

2. What conditions, if any, are necessary for an agent to have rights? (16 answers)
Candidates showed good knowledge of debates between interest and will theories of rights, but often struggled to link this to the specific question. Some answers expressed strong intuitions about the need for particular beings (infants, animals, etc.) to be able to meet or not meet the conditions of having rights but struggled to offer much argument or theoretical grounding for their judgments.

3. Should feminism retain a distinction between public and private? (59 answers)
The third most popular question. Candidates generally displayed good knowledge of feminist critiques of the public/private distinction. Weaker answers stopped there, without taking on the challenge to think about whether feminists themselves might have reason to retain the distinction. Better answers did this, often to very good effect. Better answers also offered some explicit discussion of what it might mean to retain the distinction – i.e. what the implications of this would be, with respect to both political theory and practice.

4. Should democracy be prioritised over all other political values? (24 answers)
Some candidates struggled to identify what it would mean for democracy to be prioritised over other values, sometimes leading them to claim that it should or shouldn't be without it being clear why this was the implication of the arguments they made. Better answers were clear on what they understood prioritising democracy to mean and offered thoughtful arguments regarding whether democracy should have this kind of priority.

5. Does Rawls's theory of justice adequately realise the value of equality? (73 answers)
The most popular question, answered by over half of the candidates taking the exam. The question was fairly broad, allowing for various different approaches to be taken. Weaker answers tried to take too many of these approaches at once, leading to superficial arguments. Better answers pursued one or two more sustained lines of discussion. Candidates displayed a decent basic understanding of Rawls's theory, although there was a tendency to present objections rather uncritically, without thinking about whether Rawls's theory contained resources to respond to them. Better answers showed greater understanding of both the content and motivation for the theory, and how it related to positions such as luck egalitarianism and relational egalitarianism.

6. Are 'colour-blind' policies the ultimate aim of racial justice? (23 answers)
This question was generally well answered, with candidates showing good knowledge of debates concerning racial justice, including questions of both redistribution and recognition, and of how contemporary policies should respond to historic injustice. Weaker answers rehearsed objections to colour-blind policies without considering whether such policies might nonetheless be the 'ultimate aim' of racial justice. Better answers recognised the potential for the ultimate aim to differ from the aim that we should pursue in the short term. There were some differences in what candidates

understood ‘ultimate aim’ to mean – which is of course fine, as long as their interpretation was clear and somewhat plausible.

7. **‘Individuals will always be vulnerable to arbitrary interference, and so freedom as non-domination is an unattainable ideal.’ Discuss. (63 answers)**

This was the second most popular question, which was perhaps surprising given that it was fairly specific, and focused on republican conceptions of liberty rather than the more commonly discussed debate between negative and positive conceptions. It was pleasing to see that many candidates had good understanding of the republican view, with some showing awareness of very recent literature on the topic. Many good answers considered vulnerability to both state and non-state interference, and ways that vulnerability might be avoided, with some defending revisions to the republican conception in order to secure this. Some candidates also offered insightful arguments regarding whether or not the consequent in the titular statement follows from the antecedent.

8. **To what extent, if at all, does one’s personal evaluation of a law affect one’s obligation to obey it? (56 answers)**

Another popular question, but also a difficult one. As is often the case with political obligation questions, some candidates could not resist the temptation to run through multiple accounts of political obligation and debate the merits of each, which often distracted from the specific question. Weaker answers often didn’t have a stable understanding of whether the question (and their argument) was about the law in general or particular laws. Better essays reflected directly on the reasons that we might have to answer the specific question in the affirmative or negative, with a pleasing variety of arguments offered. Some strong answers drew on the literature on civil disobedience.

9. **Is conservatism better understood as a political disposition or an ideology? (11 answers)**

Some candidates struggled to conceptualise ‘political disposition’ and ‘ideology’ in a way that opened space for insightful arguments. Candidates showed good knowledge of central conservative thinkers, and some also displayed familiarity with more recent literature on this topic.

10. **‘Global inequalities are morally arbitrary, and justice therefore requires global redistribution.’ Discuss. (41 answers)**

This was another question were there was a temptation to rehearse familiar debates, in this case about the scope of distributive justice, without focusing on the specific issue of the role that moral arbitrariness might play in justifying global redistribution. Some good answers considered whether moral arbitrariness was either necessary or sufficient (or both) for justice to require global redistribution. Others considered the ways in which global inequalities might be, or not be, morally arbitrary and the implication of this for the question.

11. **How can we tell the difference between benign social influence and objectionable relations of power? (25 answers)**

This question attracted some very good answers, drawing upon a range of approaches to power. The best answers considered both how benign social influence and objectionable power relations might be distinguished in theory and whether we were able to identify each phenomenon in practice, with some using the need for the latter as a means of assessment for accounts of the former. Weaker answers tended for rehearse Foucauldian themes without clearly explaining how the categories of benign social influence and objectionable relations of power might (or even could) fit into such an understanding.

12. ‘Since citizens disagree as much about justice as about the good, political liberalism either is incoherent or leads to anarchism.’ Discuss. (23 answers)

This was a challenging question, due to the various possibilities it suggests. Stronger answers navigated this well, showing good knowledge of attempts that political liberal theorists have made to respond to this issue. Weaker answers displayed only a superficial understanding of political liberalism, often struggled to explain the way in which citizens’ disagreements concerning justice and the good might or might not differ from one another and didn’t pay enough attention to unpacking the supposed dilemma. This sometimes stemmed from reading ‘political liberalism’ as referring to all liberal political theories, rather than specifically to views committed to some idea of public justification or public reason. The former reading is fine in itself but makes it harder to make sense of the puzzle suggested in the question.

204 Modern British Politics and Government

1. Would a codified constitution reduce ambiguities about how power is distributed in the British system of government? (5 answers)

This question was generally well answered, and though there was range of marks most essays presented a nicely structured essays on the constitution. There was reference both to literature and documents, with knowledge of constitutional principles throughout, some strong points in particular on executive power, and some more ambiguous work on this question in the context of Parliament. Several essays made good use of the conceptual distinction between legal and constitutional ambiguity to answer the question. Weaker answers lack some detail and on this occasion the lack of use of the literature was problematic

2. Have the events of British politics since 2010 undermined or strengthened Parliament's ability to scrutinise the executive? (10 answers)

Answers to this question generally fell in the mid-2:1 range. Many displayed good coverage of the whole period, from providing summaries of the Wright reforms (e.g. elected committee chairs and the backbench business committee), to showing a good understanding of the Miller I and II cases and coverage (though somewhat more limited) of the recent effects of Covid. There was some good use of literature, particularly using King's modes of executive-legislative relations and, Norton and Cowley and Russell's responses. While there was some coverage of the Lords was also good, this tended to lack some detail. Weaker answers were more limited in scope, for example not considering changing norms of behaviour related to minority/coalition government and only covering very recent changes.

3. Is the Prime Minister always the predominant actor within the executive in the UK? (8 answers)

Answers on this question were generally strong, with some excellent answers. Most answers were well fortified with examples of recent prime ministers and were generally well structured but again lacking some literature and depth of analysis. Some showed good knowledge of examples of how PMs wield power, and there was use of the core executive and presidentialisation models (but answers generally lacked other approaches like Skowronek's political time approach). There was also some good detail on development of the executive in terms of staff, and how the Coalition was structured. Weaker answers lacked this detailed perspective and were somewhat lighter on a broader range of theoretical perspectives and literature

4. Does the Civil Service require fundamental reforms to deal with the challenges of twenty-first century government? (8 answers)

This question was overall very well answered, with most essays well embedded in research informed literature for an up to date scholarly picture of the civil service. Answers showed in particular good knowledge of the 2012 civil service reform plan and issues around accountability of the civil service to ministers. There was excellent use of the course's prescribed documents. There was also good evidence and statistics cited, with some points on diversity of the CC particularly interesting. Weaker answers were lacking in a focused

argument, rather presenting broad ranging discussions of the issues. Few answers established really clear evidentiary criteria for what the challenges of twenty first century governance are – which weakened answers overall.

5. Are claims that the judiciary has expanded its power and autonomy within British government since 2005 justified? (10 answers)

This question was again answered well for the most part, with essays generally well informed on the operation of the courts and well backed up with evidence informed literature. There was discussion of declarations of incompatibility of the HRA, and some nice, detailed analysis of particular cases, as well as near-universal recognition of the context of the question being the 2005 Constitutional Reform Act. The best answers distinguished power from autonomy, rightly seeing them as different, and showed detailed knowledge of developments in UK judicial politics, embedded in a deeper understanding of constitutional principles. Weaker answers were somewhat overly focused on the Miller cases decisions and a little derivative in terms of how they were summarised.

6. "If a country wants a highly representative parliament, where the assembly is a microcosm of the pluralism of opinions in society, a proportional representation (PR) system is best. Alternatively, if a country wants the party that wins the most votes in an election to form a stable single-party government, a majoritarian system is best." (JOHN M CAREY AND SIMON HIX). To what extent does this explain differences between the Westminster and devolved parliaments in the UK? (2 answers)

Too few answers to comment.

7. Does the regulation of lobbying and interest groups in the UK open the door to corruption? (1 answer)

Too few answers to comment.

8. To what extent is the British political system influenced by the way political parties raise and spend money? (3 answers)

Too few answers to comment.

9. Have voter perceptions of governing competence declined in importance in explaining electoral outcomes in the UK? (4 answers)

The few answers on this question were generally good use of the research literature, and familiarity with concepts which have been used to explain voting in the UK. Most mounted a clear argument for one position or the other which exploited the intersection between dealignment, new cleavages and valence voting to produce some interesting responses. The best answers showed theoretical sophistication in disaggregation of competency, awareness of key literature, good and specific use of evidence and consideration of how the question varies between countries. Weaker essays used a somewhat more conventional and basic approach – with not much interrogation of the detailed evidence for the points advanced, or not dealing at all with core ideas like rising authoritarian-liberal divides.

10. Would a federal UK, with devolution to an English parliament, resolve or exacerbate tensions within the Union? (5 answers)

This was one of the weaker set of answers overall. Some essays showed good knowledge of key issues such as the west Lothian question and the Barnett formula, but arguments for the difficulty of moving forward were more limited – focusing on the implausibility of an English parliament on demographic grounds, or sometimes UK constitutional arrangements and parliamentary sovereignty. However, this still led to somewhat meandering discussions which lacked a clear line of argument or failed spell out the reasons for the conclusion reached.

11. Did the Leveson inquiry result in any long-term changes in the way the British press operates? (No answers)

12. Have the objectives set out by the proponents of leaving the European Union been achieved by the final agreement reached in December 2020? (1 answer)

Too few answers to comment.

205 Government and Politics of the US

Question	Number of Answers
1	5
2	2
3	2
4	4
5	5
6	6
7	0
8	2
9	9
10	1
11	5
12	4

The spread of questions taken was fairly diverse; the most popular question was 9 on the Supreme Court and precedent, and there were sadly no takers for the question on bureaucracy. In general, the standard of answers was solid, with few really weak answers; nearly all the answers showed considerable knowledge of a wide literature and at least broadly attempted to engage with the question.

Some notes on particular questions:

1. Answers were generally more inclined to say that American exceptionalism was useful, than to identify what or who it was useful for, although the best answers addressed this thoughtfully.

5. Many obstacles were proposed as factors making it increasingly difficult to make major changes to public policy, sometimes without much reference to changes in public policy. The best answers at least considered how good the evidence was that such changes were increasingly difficult.

6. Weaker answers took the question as a jumping off point for a discussion of presidential power in the round, while stronger answers tried to engage with both sides of the quite nuanced point made in the quotation.

9. It seemed clear that the leak of Justice Alito's draft opinion in *Dobbs* had engaged candidates' interest in *stare decisis* to a degree unforeseen when the question was set. On the whole answers were informed and responsive to the question, though few answers had any theory of why precedents might sometimes be abandoned and sometimes not, or whether it was possible to retain precedents without respecting them.

11. Generally well answered by candidates who had a lot to say on the subject; occasionally these came close to simple assertion rather than argument. The best essays looked to the historical development of racial politics to generate subtle arguments about the connection between the two kinds of race-conscious policy.

206 Politics in Europe

There were four scripts. Two scripts were excellent, and two scripts achieved results in the mid-60s.

The quality of individual answers was generally high, with essays focusing on the questions at hand and using relevant theoretical and empirical material to develop arguments and explanations.

Out of the 12 questions, eight questions attracted at least one answer. Four questions received no attempt. The detailed question breakdown is as follows.

Question	Number of answers
1	1
2	0
3	2
4	2
5	0
6	1
7	0
8	2
9	0
10	1
11	1
12	2

While no individual question attracted a sufficient number of answers to be able to provide detailed comments, the examiners made the following overall observations:

1. Essays showed good knowledge of different approaches in the literature and nicely grouped arguments into different sides of a debate (e.g. demand- vs. supply-side, institutional vs. non-institutional arguments).
2. Stronger essays clearly defined key terms in the question and made suggestions for how they can be captured empirically.
3. Some questions included statements about general trends in European politics. Stronger essays assessed the empirical accuracy of these statements, including with regard to whether there is any notable cross-national variation in the phenomenon of interest and, if yes, whether/how this cross-national variation affects our confidence in statements about overall general trends.
4. Stronger essays engaged with readings and findings on both Western and Eastern Europe and reflected on the extent to which we can generalize across the two macro-regions.
5. Essays generally provided some empirical evidence for their proposed arguments. Weaker essays relied on case-specific illustrations without justifying the selection of these cases. Stronger essays made use of the comparative and quantitative evidence presented in the readings and lectures.
6. Among others, scripts differed in the extent to which they made use of the readings. Stronger essays referenced specific readings in the author-year format when developing their arguments.

207 Politics in Russia and the Former Soviet Union

11 candidates took this examination: 8 PPE students and 3 HPol students, and 1 candidate was absent. The standard was high. Marks ranged from 64 to 73, with an overall average of 68. Four candidates achieved a First-Class mark.

Frequency of responses: low (up to 3), high (more than 3).

1. **Why did Mikhail Gorbachev attempt to reform the Soviet system? (High)**

   The stronger answers engaged with the competing debates, with particular emphasis on Gorbachev's ideological motivation. Weaker answers did not consider the 'objective' problems facing the USSR and focused instead on Gorbachev's reforms.

2. **Does the concept of revolution explain the overthrow of Soviet Communism? (Low)**

   Fewer students answered this question. Candidates discussed the applicability of Skocpol's definition of revolution, and generally displayed good knowledge of the Soviet period. However, answers were weaker in discussing the mass basis to perestroika.

3. **Compare and contrast the successes and failures of market reforms in post-Soviet economies. (Low)**

   Few students answered this question. Stronger answers showed a good understanding of the policies in different post-Soviet states and the competing debates in the literature on the factors that explain the success and failure of reforms.

4. **'Competitive authoritarianism is a stable regime outcome in post-Soviet Eurasia.' Discuss. (None)**

5. **In what ways is the rigidity of presidentialism perilous for post-Soviet political systems? (Low)**

   Stronger scripts discussed Linz's understanding of rigidity in the post-Soviet context and the problem of term limits. They showed good comparative understanding of different presidents in the region.

6. **Under what conditions have opposition parties exerted influence over post-Soviet political developments? (Low)**

   The stronger answers focused on the contribution that opposition parties have made to the consolidation of electoral authoritarianism. They also discussed how these systems provide opportunities for opposition parties to lead electoral protest.

7. **Why do post-Soviet citizens cast votes in support of incumbent regimes and candidates? (None)**

8. **Why do some post-Soviet protests succeed while others fail? (High)**
   This question produced strong answers. Candidates distinguished between different forms of protest and discussed both supply and demand-side factors that contribute to

the success and failure of protest. The stronger answers provided good comparative examples.

9. 'Whereas nationalism in the late Soviet period destroyed regimes, in the post-Soviet period it has conserved them.' Is this assessment accurate and if so, why? (High)

Candidates focused mainly on the Soviet period; there was less discussion of post-Soviet nationalism. Stronger answers attempted to discuss the difference in the drivers of nationalism in both periods.

10. Is the political effect of natural resources better understood as the result of deterministic forces or elite choices? (High)

Most candidates answered this question. The stronger scripts discussed the conditional effects of natural resources, placing particular emphasis on the role of elites, electoral cycles, institutional arrangements, and the ways in which rents are distributed, with a focus on the ownership of firms. The problem of endogeneity was discussed in most answers.

11. Are typologies of post-Soviet corruption useful? (Low)

One candidate answered this question.

12. How far do 'Soviet legacies' help us to explain post-Soviet outcomes? (Low)

One candidate answered this question.

208 Politics in Sub-Saharan Africa

As is the case with other papers, the 2022 examination saw a return to the exam conditions that were the rule until the Covid epidemic: a three-hour invigilated examination, in contrast with 2020 and 2021. The students answered the examinations very well and demonstrated excellent knowledge and the ability to coherently structure arguments. Of the nineteen students who took the exam, seven had 1st class performances and twelve were at 2:1 level. There were no weak performances, and the general quality of the essays was high. This is very positive although, as was the case in 2021, the number of outstanding performances was smaller than in previous years (there was only one script at 77%, which showed intellectual originality of the highest calibre). However, the general level remained high, with virtually no weak or disappointing scripts.

Marks across essays were often consistent or at least showed few major disparities and time management did not seem to be a major issue for most students. Students were most often able to maintain consistency across all three essays and many 2.1. performances were concentrated in the upper 2.1. area. Eleven questions were engaged with and only one question (11) was not tackled by candidates. While there was less budging around certain essay topics than in previous years, questions 1, 3 and 10 on structural adjustment, women's rights and liberation movements were tackled more often. There was a very good spread across many of the remaining questions, even if questions on ideology and the politics of land attracted only one essay each. Religion, ethnicity, the political economy of development and the politics of conflict proved popular and generally attracted essays of a good standard. The popular question on the politics of economy reform had generally good essays, but many emphasised structural/global explanations and insufficiently engaged with notions of African agency and the changes brought to Africa's international economic relations by the presence of emerging powers such as China.

One of the most positive dimensions of this year's exams is the way students drew on a wide range of case studies and on more interesting arguments. Despite this improvement which we already noted last year, candidates should continue to be aware of the need to relate interesting evidence with a broader set of arguments than the ones sometimes brought forth. The essays on gender were again consistently good, as were those on military matters. The best essays in this examination were again those that engaged the literature in a judicious and evidence-based way, rather than those that embraced well-worn positions in the literature.

Some candidates, though fewer than in the past, still lost marks for failing to define key terms or to answer all parts of a question. Those candidates that did engage with key concepts and major comparative debates in the literature developed better contributions and were rewarded accordingly. One positive aspect of this year's paper, in line with the previous years, is that students answered questions with reference to no less than thirty-five different sub-Saharan African states and showed a strong commitment to sustained comparison. The over-concentration on one case study, and its deployment across several essays, was a rare occurrence. The Francophone states of West Africa and the Horn of Africa, which were insufficiently engaged with only a few years ago, continued to see a serious amount of engagement.

The candidates could still do a better job in three areas which have been flagged out in the exam reports of previous years. First, the candidates could provide a more nuanced scoping of their answer: how representative are the cases they draw on? How were the examples chosen, and how are they situated in time and space? How generalizable are the suggested

conclusions? Second, candidates could make an effort to tackle essays, especially those that lend themselves to potentially predictable treatments (especially the politics of economic reform), in a more deliberately original manner, both theoretically and in terms of engaging with a broader range of case-studies. Third, and perhaps most important: a small number of candidates were beholden to one major scholarly reference and paraphrased its contents, used the same case studies, and came to similar conclusions as the authors of said study. Candidates are expected to have read widely and to have grasped the plurality of contributions to these debates. For the most part, this is what those taking this exam have done.

While these points need to be kept in mind, the overall level of empirical and theoretical sophistication of this set of scripts was again of a very high standard.

209 Politics in Latin America

This paper was taken by twelve PPE candidates and four HPol candidates. Following the disruptions of the pandemic, this year, we returned to in-person handwritten exams. Despite the change of delivery, and the fact that this cohort did not sit Prelims, many of the scripts proved to be of very high quality. There were two clear first-class honours, together with thirteen upper seconds and one lower second. All the scripts demonstrated a very good understanding of the wider theoretical literature and as is always the case with this exam, the stronger scripts matched this theoretical knowledge with solid empirical knowledge. The very best scripts could successfully critically engage with the theoretical models and could illustrate the theoretical dynamics with reference to the actual politics of the region. The weaker scripts struggled to engage with some of the more complicated theoretical ideas in the literature and these scripts also struggled to demonstrate empirical knowledge. Below is the distribution of answers, by question:

Question	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
N	9	3	5	-	4	4	1	4	10	6	1	1

This year, we saw a slight retreat from the previous trend for a greater spread in the choice of questions among candidates and a return to a focus on specific questions. Two questions, in particular, attracted a disproportionate amount of attention this year: Question 1 on state capacity and Question 9 on democratic transitions. Question 3 (on electoral behaviour) produced some of the strongest answers this year. There were no attempts at Question 4 (IPE).

210 Politics in South Asia

Twelve questions were set in this year's paper, with seven out of the twelve attempted by the six candidates who sat the examination. The most popular question (answered by all six candidates) was Question 7, which asked whether caste is a colonial category. The best answers to Question 7 were able to critically examine the relationship between colonialism and caste and also trace the development of caste as a category in contemporary Indian/South Asian politics; the very best did so with depth and nuance. Question 6, focusing on whether politics in South Asia can be understood without factoring in the role of religion, and Question 2, which asked candidates to weigh up whether colonial institutional legacies or post-colonial institutional choices have mattered most in South Asian state-building, were each answered by three candidates. Questions 1, 4, 5 and 10, focussing on SAARC/regionalism, the regionalisation of politics in India, nuclear deterrence between India and Pakistan, and social movements, were each answered by between 1 and 2 candidates. Questions 3, 8, 9, 11, and 12, focussing on the link between South Asian autarky and economic growth and development; the link between foreign policy and unequal citizenship; the continuing relevance of caste the relationship between India's democratic upsurge and social equality; and the regional/global context of nationalism in South Asia, respectively, were not attempted. These were also, however, not questions that were popular among students during the Hilary Term revision classes. The spread of marks awarded (for the examination as a whole) was reasonably narrow, ranging from 65% (mid 2.1) to 71% (a low 1st). Three candidates scored a low 1st and three scored a mid or a high 2.1. Overall, the answers demonstrated sound empirical knowledge. Weaker answers were overly brief, descriptive or 'listy', failed to closely address the question, advanced either a simplistic argument or a singular argument with no alternatives considered, or delivered only a partial answer. Stronger answers developed a systematic framework for the analysis and were targeted, systematic, empirically rich, critically engaged and demonstrated broad coverage of the literature.

211 Politics in the Middle East

Summary

- The modal student received an Upper Second-class classification; the lowest mark was 58 and the highest mark was 73
- The most popular question was: “2. Is the electoral appeal of Islamist movements best understood as resulting from the failure of other political projects and ideologies?”. The second most popular question was: “What are the political consequences of oil rents?”. The least answered question was: “9. How have refugees shaped the politics of host states in the MENA?”
- The highest marks achieved by question (median ≥ 70) were for protest (Q.6), Islamist violence/ethnicity (Q.8), and elections (Q.10); the lowest marks (median = 62) were achieved on questions related to refugees (Q.9) and welfare politics/economic liberalisation (Q.11)

Background

The paper was convened by Neil Ketchley, who was also the first marker. The other examiners were Yaacov Yadgar and Ceren Lord. In total, 45 students attempted the exam. Fourteen were reading for History & Politics; the balance were from PPE.[1]

Mark distribution

Figure 1 shows the distribution of agreed overall marks, which is bi-modal with 20 percent of students receiving a 69 and 20 percent receiving a 71. Looking across the entire distribution, 69 percent of students received an Upper Second.

Questions answered

Figure 2 shows the distribution of exam responses by questions answered. In ascending order, the most popular questions related to Islamists and elections (Q.2), oil (Q.12), women (Q.5), and colonialism (Q.1). The least popular questions were on

[1]Linear regression suggests that there was no statistical difference in exam marks by degree program ($p = .99$ for the null hypothesis).

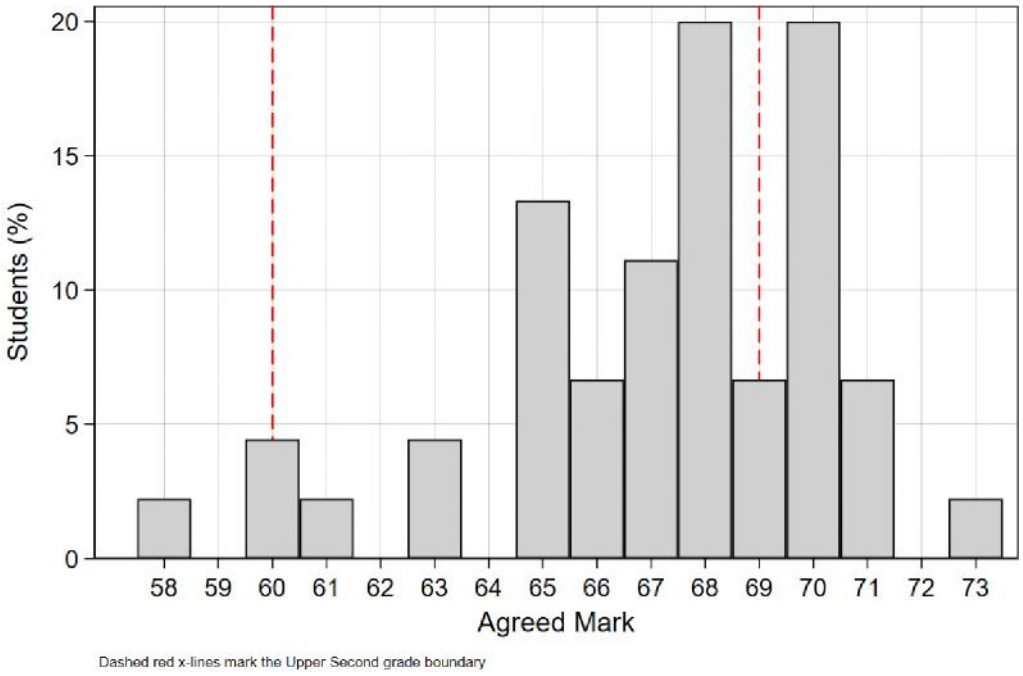


Figure 1: Agreed marks

refugees (Q.9), Islamist violence/ethnicity (Q.8), coercive state institutions (Q.4), and welfare politics/economic liberalisation (Q.11). Note that the topic on refugees was introduced into the syllabus for the first time in 2021-22, and so finalists who took the paper in their second year would not have prepared for it.

Marks by question

Figure 3 are box plots showing the distribution of marks for each question. Note that these grades are from the first marker only. Note also that for questions with only a small number of observations, only the median is plotted; outliers are marked by blacks dots. The lowest mark received for a question was 58; the highest was 78. The highest marks achieved by question (median $\geq$ 70) were for protest (Q.6), Islamist violence/ethnicity (Q.8), and elections (Q.10); the lowest marks (median = 62) were achieved on questions related to refugees (Q.9) and wel-fare/liberalisation (Q.11). In interpreting these distributions, note that questions 8, 9, and 11 encompass only a small number of observations. The largest spread of grades (measured by the interquartile range) were achieved on questions related to Islamists and elections (Q.2), protest (Q.6), and welfare politics/economic liberalisation (Q.11).

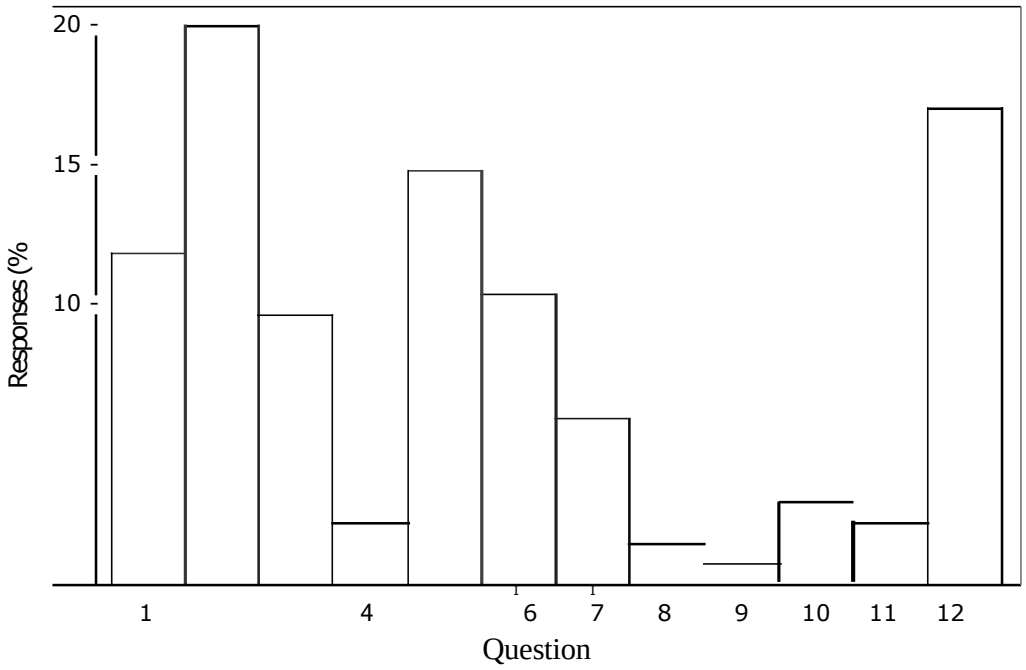


Figure 2: Questions answered

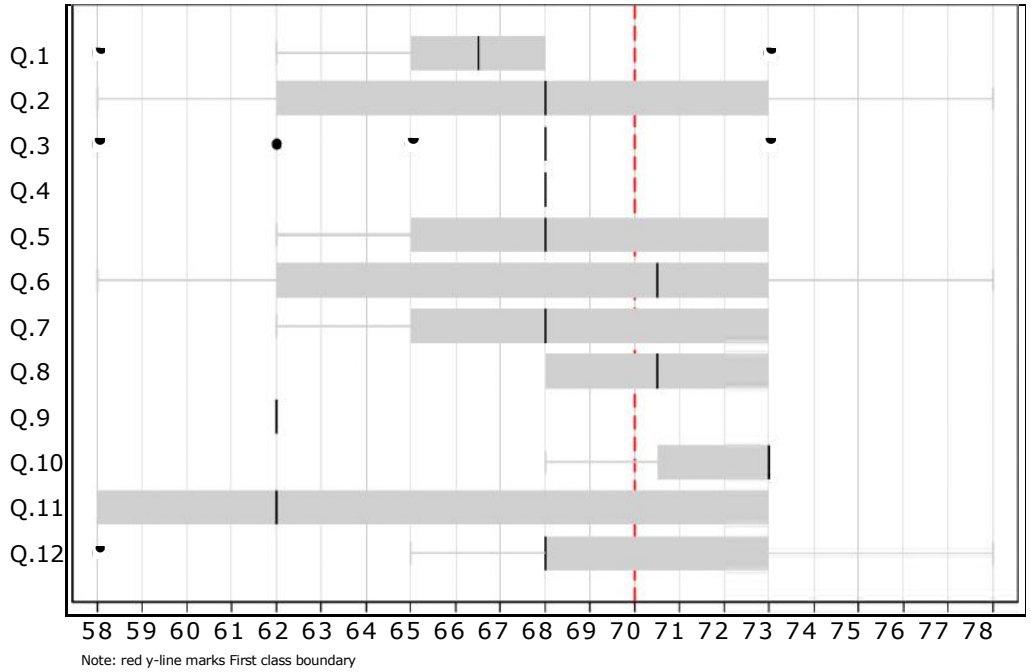


Figure 3: Marks by question

212 International Relations in the Era of Two World Wars

This paper had significantly fewer takers this year than in previous years, with four PPE students taking it, and none from History and Politics. It is possible that students on the latter degree are taking papers on Global History for similar or overlapping periods.

The paper was reasonably well answered, with an average mark of 66%. There was one First Class script, two Upper Second Class, and one Lower Second Class. The most popular question was Q1 on the origins of the First World War and imperialism (with a wide range in quality among them), but overall, there were too few takers to comment on individual questions and answers.

213 International Relations in era of the Cold War

Total number of exam scripts: 22

General remarks: Overall, competent essays. The difference between a strong and weak essay usually came down to a) the level of detail presented in historical material and b) whether the student presented a clear, analytical argument alongside regurgitation of historical events. The strongest essays were able to draw out conceptual discussions on core ideas and theoretical arguments by using historical examples.

Q1: 10 (45.5%)
A relatively popular question, students generally presented fair understanding of relevant material. The difference between a competent essay and a very good essay came down to whether the student focused on the key parameter of the question (was it *necessary* for the USSR to collapse), rather than discussing generally about the conditions leading to the end of the Cold War. Some variances in structure and coherency were also shown.

Q2: 5 (22.7%)
Generally resulted in competent essays that answered the question, showed fair range of command of material. Weaker essays had difficulty clearly defining core concept and its underlying theoretical argument ('mutually assured destruction').

Q3: 3 (13.6%)
Generally resulted in competent essays that addressed the question fully.

Q4: 16 (72.7%)
A very popular question; essay quality varied across the board. Overall, on the lower end of the marking scheme, students tended to regurgitate different historical events and details in chronological order. More successful essays were able to draw out broader theoretical arguments and conceptual discussions (e.g. nature of the 'beginning' of Cold War; discussion on structure vs. agency; role of individuals vs. structural forces…).

Q5: 9 (40.9%)
Generally resulted in competent essays; students overall showed a lot of confidence in using empirical illustrations.

Q6: 3 (13.6%)
Few students attempted this question, but all three essays were very strong. Essays all showed evidence of independent thinking.

Q7: 0 (0%)

Q8: 8 (36.4%)
Showed wide variance in terms of marks – some very strong essays and some of the weaker essays of the batch came from this question. Stronger essays were able to draw out a clear line of argument using key empirical evidence effectively, while weaker essays over-focused on details on some domestic factors while neglecting others or counter-examples.

Q9: 4 (18.2%)

Generally strong essays that demonstrated good historical knowledge of the USSR's role in Eastern Europe. Stronger essays had better conceptual discussion on what 'imperialism' meant.

Q10: 1 (4.5%)
Weaker essay that showed competent writing structurally, but analysis was a bit uneven.

Q11: 4 (18.2%)
Overall competent essays that demonstrated good knowledge of history.

Q12: 2 (9.1%)
Both very strong essays that addressed the question fully and showed good command of the historical material. Presented clear conceptual discussion on what is a 'proxy war'.

214 International Relations

148 candidates sat this paper. 121 were PPE and 27 were HP. The combined (PPE plus HP) mean was 66.4, the top mark was 79, and the bottom mark was 53. The concentration in the mid to high 60s range suggests a very good command of the paper. The number of 70+ grades (26.4%) seems a bit high to me, and the number of marks in the 50's range seems a bit low (compared to past years). Perhaps markers should be encouraged to be somewhat more critical, but without sight of results from other papers it is hard to be definitive here.

Cooperation among markers in exchanging papers and in reconciling marks was unproblematic. A small number of scripts that markers could not reconcile were sent out for a third marking, as is normal.

Considering the exam questions, I agree with the previous examiner that there is some overlap with other papers (notably 297 – security), which, I guess, is unavoidable. There is also a continuing problem with boilerplate answers that seemingly had been pre-prepared and often did not address directly the question posed. An example would be Q4, which focussed on military intervention in the post-Cold War era and what that tells us about the nature of power. Here, many simply recited the debates about power with little discussion of the intervention aspect. I note that the power question is generally more popular than it was in this round, probably because of the focus on intervention.

Unsurprisingly, once again scripts seemed to cluster around four or five questions. For example, Q12 (clash of civilizations) was extremely popular, with mixed results. Many other questions were rarely attempted (e.g., Q2 on law or Q6 on limitations of liberal assumptions on IR in the post-Cold War era). Some markers were concerned by the overlap between questions (e.g., Q3 on critical theory and Q5 on post-colonial IR scholarship).

In general, however, this was a good year for 214.

215 Political Thought: Plato to Rousseau

15 students sat the exam this year, which is slightly down from last year. Overall, the standard was high, and there were a few really stunning first-class papers. More students attempted the "theme" questions than in previous years, to excellent effect.

In general, excellent answers addressed all parts of the question in a well-organized argument. First-class essays exhibited 1) independent judgment based on close textual argument; 2) the integration of historical context; and 3) familiarity with arguments in the secondary literature. They argued on the basis of specific features of the text and considered counter- or supporting arguments found in the scholarly literature. Appeals to context were well-integrated into the arguments, and not rote repetition from lectures. They also showed discrimination in considering what points mattered in answering the question. Weaker essays failed to address the question asked, relied on simplistic summaries and incorrect assumptions about the text/context, or else simply rehearsed without expanding upon material from the lectures. Many tried to throw everything they could remember at the question and were accordingly disorganized and difficult to follow.

1. **'Appearances to the contrary, Plato's Republic (*Politeia*) is a persuasive defence of democracy.' Discuss. (5 answers)**

Questions on Plato are usually the most popular, but not this year, perhaps due to the counter-intuitive prompt. The very best answers acknowledged its counter-intuitiveness, then argued with or against it, demonstrating an impressive range of knowledge about *Republic* and the historical context of democratic Athens. Some rightly associated this view with commentators like Allan Bloom. Some students answered the question they wished had been asked, rather than the question asked, or focused on Book 1 to the exclusion of Book VIII, which was a problem.

2. **What, according to Aristotle, is the *best* regime? Why does he insist on offering an answer to this question? (10 answers)**

By far the most popular question this year, with some really impressive essays showing knowledge of not only *Politics* but *Ethics*. A few essays deployed contextualist readings of Aristotle in light of the rise of Macedon to good effect. A few students stumbled on the difference between the "best/ideal" regime in Aristotle and the "best possible," offering essays on polity instead of virtue-monarchy/aristocracy. The very best essays focused on Aristotle's methodology and the role of the "best" in teleological arguments.

3. **What is the 'state of innocence', according to Aquinas, and what role does it play in his political theory? (1 answer)**

Too few to comment.

4. **'More's *Utopia* is nothing but Greek nonsense.' Discuss. (0 answers)**
5. **"While pretending to teach lessons to kings, he taught great lessons to the people. Machiavelli's *Prince* is the book of republicans" (ROUSSEAU). Discuss. (7 answers)**

Tied for the second-most popular question. The best essays considered the *Discorsi* as well as the *Prince* and the tradition of 'republicanism' as a frame for understanding Machiavelli's project. Most essays rejected Rousseau's reading on the basis of evidence. Some essays deployed context well, focusing on Machiavelli's relationship to the Soderini regime in Florence. Some essays foregrounded Machiavelli's populism in the *Prince* to good effect. Weak essays ignored the *Discorsi* entirely.

6. **Why does Hobbes stress throughout *Leviathan* that the Sovereign can be either "one Man" or "one Assembly of men." (7 answers)**

Also tied for second. A range of answers—some students clearly did not remember this feature of Hobbes's argument and struggled to reconcile it with what they took to be his unflinching monarchism, others rightly noted the prudential nature of his preference for monarchy. The best essays appealed to context without reducing the significance of this point to placating the 'Interregnum' Commonwealth in England. (Some students were confused as to whether Cromwell or Parliament was in charge when *Leviathan* was published in 1651, it was the latter.) The strongest essays focused on the nature of Hobbesian sovereignty and its key features.

7. **What role, if any, does sovereignty play in Locke's political theory? (2 answers)**

Too few to comment.

8. **Equality is the end of which regime(s), according to Montesquieu? Explain. (1 answer)**

Too few to comment.

9. **What role should the passions play in politics, according to Hume? (0 answers)**

10. **"There was once a man called Rousseau who wrote a book containing nothing but ideas. The second edition was bound in the skins of those who laughed at the first." (THOMAS CARLYLE). Discuss. (3 answers)**

Another counter-intuitive but largely open-ended prompt. The best answers took advantage of the prompt to offer their own counter-intuitive arguments about Rousseau. Although the quote is referring to *Le Contrat Social*, there were some interesting arguments offered about the *Discourses* and *Emile* as well. Contextual answers focused on Rousseau's biography, as opposed to the Revolution to come.

11. **What problem(s) does Christianity pose for politics? Does it offer any solutions? Answer with reference to <u>at least TWO</u> authors you have read for this course. (4 answers)**

The best answers demonstrated knowledge of one pre-modern (ancient/medieval) and one modern (early modern/modern) author; weaker essays bit off more than they could chew by trying to discussion 4-5 authors—too many! Some excellent discussions of Aquinas,

Machiavelli, and Hobbes in this context, although some students risked repeating themselves/replicating material from other answers. Students who did so were marked down. Some answers appealed successfully to themes in contemporary political theory.

12. Is education necessarily political? Answer with reference to at least TWO authors you have read for this course. (5 answers)

Again, more popular than in previous years, there were really excellent, original, and fun essays here. Most answers began with Plato and/or Aristotle and contrasted an ancient view of the understanding of political education with Machiavelli, Hobbes, or Rousseau. There were some ambitious answers that were clearly having fun reflecting on the students' own educational experience of reading these texts.

216 Political Thought: Bentham to Weber

This year Bentham to Weber attracted a strong pool of candidates who performed very well on the exam. Of 11 scripts no paper received lower than a 2:1 mark and there were three papers with an overall first-class mark. Several candidates received first-class marks on at least one question.

Every year examiners note that the most successful answers advance a high level of primary, secondary, and contextual knowledge while offering clear and cogent arguments in response to the question. This year is no different. It was particularly heartening to see so many students engage closely with the texts, bringing to the attention of the examiner peculiarities of a thinker's position that the candidate then used to respond to the question. While it is of course perfectly possible to achieve a first-class mark on the basis of the set texts alone, there did seem to be a correlation between the very best scripts and those which went beyond the set texts in their answers.

Students are reminded of the value of tying arguments about authors to their texts. Authors rarely theorise just one view across all works, and even if they do, there are usually nuances across the various versions.

Finally, students who wish to take a more squarely philosophical approach to the question should remember that they ought still to use the text – or at least refer to the text – to make their arguments.

1. **'Saint Simon was a utopian, but he was no socialist.' Discuss. (4 answers)**

The best used close textual engagement to weigh both sides of the question. It was not necessary to engage with question via Marx's views on Saint Simon in The Communist Manifesto but at least one candidate did so successfully.

2. **Is there any justice to Marx's complaint that Bentham was the 'oracle of the ordinary bourgeois intelligence of the 19th century'? (1 answer)**

This was a tough question, but it was also an opportunity to show off a wide range of knowledge of the period.

3. **In the Preface to the *Elements of the Philosophy of Right* (1821) Hegel defines philosophy as the 'exploration of the rational'. In what sense is his own work a contribution to that project? (3 answers)**

The trick with Hegel is to use the text as much as possible and either to avoid getting caught up in jargon drawn from secondary literature or to make sure those terms of art are properly explicated.

4. **Why do some readers see a tension between Marx's theory of revolution and his own attempts to call the working class to revolutionary consciousness? Are they right to? (6 answers)**

This question showed that there are a range of ways to do well on this paper. Some candidates used Marx's text to engage closely with e.g. Cohen and were successful, others

referred to the debates in the secondary literature but focussed more closely on Marx and his project. Both approaches yielded strong answers as long as the text did not slip too far from view.

5. **What role, if any, does self-sacrifice play in Tocqueville's vision of democracy? (5 answers)**

Tocqueville's presence on the first-year syllabus means that answers need really to distinguish themselves from a Prelims level answer. Simply discussing the tyranny of the majority and soft despotism is insufficient for a strong mark. The best answers showed close engagement with Tocqueville's texts and thought surprisingly and interestingly about the implications of the question.

6. **Why does Mill think that political theorists need to know about history and what role does historical understanding play in his own political thought? (1 answer)**

A pity because a question like this allows students to think through all sorts of interesting themes in Mill's thought.

7. **Did Max Weber think that politicians could be morally upright? (5 answers)**

Some students did well by offering a close reading of 'Politics as a Vocation' others by thinking about how Weber's views of politicians changed over his career.

8. **Why does Durkheim think we should attend to the division of labour in society? (2 answers)**

Two answers. A good example of how a simple question can, in the hands of a knowledgeable candidate, be turned into a way of investigating interesting tensions in a thinker's position.

9. **How should we characterise the relationship in the 19th century between a thinker's religious and political commitments? Answer with reference to at least TWO authors you have read for this course. (0 answers)**

10. **How did 19th-century authors look to protect the individual from the group? Answer with reference to at least TWO authors you have read for this course. (0 answers)**

11. **In what ways, if any, did 19th-century thinkers offer innovative theories of social change? Answer with reference to at least TWO authors you have read for this course. (0 answers)**

12. **Did 19th-century thinkers look to eliminate or consolidate the subjection of women? Answer with reference to at least TWO authors you have read for this course.**

Students who answer comparative questions are particularly reminded that the skill here is to work out how to bring textual nuance to an answer that, by necessity, allows you less space to focus too extensively on a thinker's views. Too often comparative answers remain superficial or abstracted from the particularities of author's claims.

217 Marx and Marxism

Paper sat by 23 candidates.

Number of Question:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
Number of answers:	1	10	9	5	11	8	7	5	2	2	7	2

1. **'The influence of the Left Hegelians on Marx's thought is much more significant than that of Hegel himself.' Discuss.**

[Too few answers to comment on]

2. **'Since both capitalists and workers are presumably alienated in capitalist societies, the explanatory role of Marx's account of alienation remains unclear.' Discuss.**

Not all candidates offered very clear accounts of what alienation, in general, might be, sometimes leaping straight into rehearsed accounts of the young Marx's views on alienated labour in capitalism. Some answers failed to explain fully the precise connection between the purported unclarity and the fact that both capitalists and workers are presumably alienated. And not all answers showed an awareness of passages where Marx appears to discuss possible differences between the alienation of capitalists and that of workers.

3. **Does the appeal to functional explanation in reconstructions of Marx's theory of history create more problems than it solves?**

Candidates often displayed a good understanding of Marx's theory of history, and appreciated the role played by functional explanation in modern reconstructions of that theory. However, they sometimes struggled to say very much, either in criticism of that modern appeal to functional explanation, or in reference to wider debates about the appropriate use of functional explanation in the social sciences.

4. **Does Marx have clear and persuasive reasons for identifying the proletariat as the collective agent that will bring about communism?**

The various threads in Marx's account of the strength and motivation of the relevant collective agent were not always carefully unpacked by answers to this question. The question was perhaps also not well-suited to candidates who were reluctant to take a view about the persuasiveness of Marx's reasons for identifying the proletariat as that agent; that Marx finds the reasons 'clear and persuasive' does not obviously give others a reason to do so.

5. **'Without his writings on the Paris Commune we would have little chance of making sense of Marx's idea that in a future communist society the public power loses its state-like character.' Discuss.**

Historical knowledge of the Paris Commune was in remarkably short supply in many answers to this question. Knowledge of Marx's views on the Commune was often better, but the institutional dimensions of his defence of it were often lacking in precise detail. Weaker essays often came close to treating the question merely as an opportunity for very general reflections about the character and coherence of the idea of the 'withering away' of the state.

6. What, if anything, does Marx admire in, and borrow from, the writings of the 'utopian socialists'?

Even essays containing a good understanding of Marx's own views about the so-called 'utopian socialists' often said remarkably little about the views of the Utopian Socialists themselves. It is hard to evaluate the extent and content of possible 'borrowings' from those writings without some independent knowledge of those writings. More generally, candidates should appreciate that some independent knowledge of utopian writers is needed in order to evaluate the account of those authors propounded by Marx and Engels.

7. 'The more seriously we take his account of "ideology", the less plausible Marx's insistence on the "inevitability" of socialism looks.' Discuss.

Most answers on this topic demonstrated a good understanding of the implied reasoning in the title quotation. However, answers contained an interesting variety of views about the explanatory ambition of Marx's account of ideology. Marx was variously said to have offered ideology as an explanation of: the supposedly surprising stability of class-divided societies; the supposedly surprising stability of capitalist societies, in particular; the failure of socialist revolution to materialise; the preponderance of certain kind of false or misleading social views in class-divided societies; and more.

8. Does Marx have clear and persuasive reasons for thinking that capitalist exploitation is morally wrong?

Better answers showed a good understanding of Marx's account of exploitation and considered what might precisely account for the 'moral wrongness', or even injustice, of some forms of capitalist exploitation. Weaker answers were typically less good at resisting the temptation to treat this as a very general Marx and morality question, or as a very general Marx and the injustice of capitalism question.

9. 'Despite his protestations, Bernstein's revisionism is incompatible with Marxism.' Discuss.

This is a question which ideally required good close textual knowledge of Bernstein's writings on revisionism. In addition, candidates needed to notice that the question asked, not about points at which Bernstein broke with Marx, but points at which he broke with Marxis*m*. Finally, some essays failed to appreciate that 'incompatibility' is a precise and demanding relation to establish.

10. Does recognising the possibility of a socialist revolution in economically-backwards Russia require Marxists to abandon historical materialism? Discuss with reference to TWO OR MORE authors you have studied.

This is a question ideally requiring a clear appreciation of why, for Marxists, economic backwardness might be considered incompatible with socialism. Marx was often a reference point here (one of the two authors required), and answers often demonstrated a good knowledge of the relevant Marx texts (including correspondence, and drafts). Close textual knowledge of later Marxists was always not quite as impressive.

11. Does Antonio Gramsci's account of 'hegemony' effectively abandon the traditional Marxist account of the relation between 'base' and 'superstructure'?

Close textual knowledge of Gramsci's writings was not always in evidence in the answers to this question. Not all candidates recognised that 'the traditional Marxist account' might not be equivalent to 'Marx's account'. And not all candidates had much knowledge of the intended Marxist targets (for example, Bukharin) of Gramsci's criticisms, in this context.

12. Outline and evaluate the critique of the Bolshevik revolution, or the Soviet Union, found in the writings of EITHER Rosa Luxemburg, OR Leon Trotsky.

Good answers to this question required both close textual knowledge of the selected authors, and critical skills in order to evaluate the arguments of those authors. In the case of both authors, some knowledge of the historical context of their interventions might be helpful. There is a broad literature on Marxist accounts of both the Bolshevik revolution and the Soviet Union which students should take advantage of.

218 Sociological Theory

Seven candidates took this paper. The quality of scripts was unusually high: four scripts were marked in the second class, upper division and three gained a first. Q9 (networks) was the most popular, with six answers. Q3 (interaction) and Q6 (norms) each attracted five answers, while Q2 (evolutionary psychology) attracted three. There were single answers to Q1 (rational choice) and Q4 (domination). It was pleasing to see students develop original theoretical analyses of their own experiences for the questions on social interaction by video (Q3) and on sub fusc (Q6).

220 Political Sociology

As usual, candidates showed a high level of knowledge and broad understanding of the material.

The number of instances of candidates being unclear about their main answer to the question or their main line of argument was greater than usual. The vast majority do provide one-line summary answers in the first or last sentence of their opening paragraph. Those that used the first line for this purpose and then summarised their main points in the rest of the opening paragraph were normally more effective. This is a format we would recommend for use by candidates in the future.

Those who provided some background observations and reflections before providing their main response often omitted to give the reader a summary of the essence of their argument (early on or even at all). That was particularly problematic when the arguments in the body of the essay were unclear or hard to follow.

It was nice to see candidates discussing the limitations of the evidence base they were using. This was best done with some reflection on the extent to which the evidence used could or could not be generalised, especially to other times and places. Candidates should avoid simply announcing that their answer is restricted to a particular country or set of countries, or aspect of the question, without justification, especially when the reading list includes research that would enable a broader answer.

As usual the quality seemed to vary on two distinct dimensions: knowledge of the material on the reading list and quality of argument in response to the exam question. There were also more than the usual number of instances of answers based on empirical examples without, unfortunately, relating those examples to the literature.

There was a good spread of answers across different topics. Questions where there were specific issues to point out are as follows.

1. **Why are populist-right and green parties the most class-based parties in Europe in recent years?**

Candidates typically agreed with the premise of this question but were unclear as to why. Better answers considered different interpretations of “class based”, including having supporters disproportionately from one class and voting based on class affinity or identity. Poorer answers focused almost exclusively on populist right parties and did not discuss Green voters in any depth.

3. **How and why have attitudes to immigration changed over recent decades?**

Better answers considered ways in which both the how and why aspects of this question vary between countries. Good answers also clearly distinguished between average position, salience and polarization of attitudes. Quite a few answers were internally contradictory. Typically, this involved using research showing that anti-immigrant sentiment is stronger in periodic economic downturns as an explanation for what they claimed was a steady increase over time.

4. Why do more men than women continue to be elected to public office?

Many answers focused on voter demand factors but failed to discuss the lack of evidence for these mechanisms. Good answers considered what can, and cannot, be learnt from cross-national differences among countries in the gender balance of legislatures.

5. How do wars forge national identities?

The few answers to this question were often good. The best answers teased out the way in wars shape identity from above and below.

6. How does affluence shape social attitudes?

It was unfortunately common for candidates to arbitrarily restrict the domain of their answers, especially by excluding economic attitudes. Some of the best answers systematically considered affluence at the individual and national levels separately.

7. Is there still a collective action problem for social movements?

Weaker answers did not explain the collective action problem adequately and/ or failed to talk to about whether there have been changes in the costs and benefits which collective action offers to social movement participants.

10. Why are welfare states weakest when and where they are most needed?

Very few candidates considered how this question relates to the classic modernisation claim and the empirical tendency, at a global level, for high income countries to have stronger and more generous welfare states than middle and low income countries. There is no single correct interpretation of "when and where welfare states were most needed." Better answers considered various ways of understanding this phrase.

11. 'Public service broadcasting is the only form of media that does not polarise public opinion.' Discuss.

The term public service broadcasting was understood in a variety of ways, sometimes wrongly including state propaganda. In the 100th anniversary year of the establishment of the British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC) as a public service radio broadcaster, it was surprising to see some candidates equate public service broadcasting with (any and all) television news. Better answers showed a good understanding of how the research findings on the reading list are conditional on the nature of the media and content studied.

224 Social Policy

This paper was taken by 29 students. All questions were answered by at least one student, but there was a high concentration of answers on a few questions. The most popular questions were those focusing on poverty (Q12), education (Q3) and the welfare mix (Q6). Less than three students addressed the questions on housing (Q7) and immigrants' social rights (Q1). The average mark was 65 (lowest 58, highest 75).

The strongest answers comprehensively addressed the questions, showed breadth of knowledge and understanding of core theories and policy developments in the UK and elsewhere, made use of a wide array of relevant examples, used appropriate evidence, developed coherent and complex arguments, and demonstrated independent thinking. The weakest answers failed to satisfactory address the question, lacked a definition of core concepts, showed an unbalanced use of theory and evidence or made use of limited material, remained descriptive or contained significant mistakes of interpretation.

Q	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**	**7**	**8**	**9**	**10**	**11**	**12**
A	10	5	12	3	5	12	1	8	8	2	7	14

Question 1: Family policies

The best answers provided a comprehensive overview not just of changes in explicit family policies (e.g. parental leave or childcare provision) but also of other policy areas affecting the family and gender relations, notably labour market policy or education. The best answers also clearly discussed and defined the concept of "modernised" welfare state in an historical perspective, although only few candidates clearly grasped this concept. The weakest answers provided descriptive overview of only one policy area and lacked focus on the question, particularly the second half ("modernised welfare states").

Question 2: Welfare regimes

The best answers critically appraised Esping-Andersen's concepts of decommodification or stratification, also drawing on other typologies (e.g. Titmuss threefold model or Lewis' defamilialization). The strongest answers considered these typologies and their outcomes in relation to cash transfer programmes and services using one (or multiple) policy areas, such as healthcare policy or childcare services. The weakest answers demonstrated a descriptive understanding of welfare regimes, used few or no policy examples at all, or failed to adequately distinguish between cash transfers and services.

Question 3: Education

This was one of the most popular questions (14% of overall answers). The best answers developed coherent arguments about the structural causes of educational inequalities beyond education systems, showed understanding of debates around educational outcomes and the measurement of inequalities. They also demonstrated an in-depth understanding of UK

education policy development, considering both the pros and cons of quasi-marketisation in the eradicating educational inequalities. The weakest answers provided a poor or incorrect description of the core measures and/or reforms, showed limited breadth of knowledge and failed to demonstrate knowledge of the core dilemmas in measuring educational outcomes.

Question 4: Aging

Fewer students answered this question. All candidates demonstrated a good understanding of the demographic pressures on the welfare state. The best answers critically discussed the notion of demographic ageing and dependency ratio and their implications on the intergenerational contract and the welfare state using examples from several areas of policy (e.g. healthcare, pension and social care). The weakest answers showed understanding of core material but were more limited in breadth and drew on limited evidence from a single area of policy (e.g. pension) or dimension (e.g. taxation).

Question 5: Agenda setting

The best answers showed knowledge and critical understanding of theories of agenda setting, differentiated between structural and political determinants, and used a wide range of examples to demonstrate their applicability to social policy development in the UK. The weakest answers provided either only a descriptive overview of theories of agenda setting or focused on a wide array of examples with limited evidence of knowledge and understanding of key theoretical perspectives.

Question 6: Welfare mix

This was one of the most popular questions, accounting for 12 (14%) of overall answers. The best answers provided nuanced interpretation of shifts in the UK welfare mix under different governments and critically evaluated the advantages and disadvantages of state vs. market provided welfare with respect to clearly defined criteria (e.g., quality, efficiency, citizenship). The weakest answers provided only descriptive overviews of policy changes without discussing their strengths and weaknesses, lacked a coherent argument and were more limitedly focused on single aspects (e.g., financing, regulation, provision of welfare services).

Question 8: Healthcare

The best answers demonstrated an excellent command of the literature on healthcare policy development and knowledge of legislation after 1980. They clearly differentiated between economic and political motivations and carefully traced their meaning and salience in the development of the British healthcare system under different government. They also demonstrated understanding of debates around notions of ‘choice’, ‘health inequalities’ and ‘individual responsibility’. The weakest answers provided descriptive or vague accounts of healthcare policies, contained inaccuracies around the structure of healthcare in the UK,

failed to demonstrate a clear understanding of the drivers of healthcare reform or showed an unbalanced attention to only one type of factors.

Question 9: Conditionality and activation

The best answers provided a comprehensive and well-structured overview of reforms affecting benefit conditionality and activation policies in the United Kingdom, their political motives, and consequences on different aspects of labour market performance (e.g., employment, unemployment, precarious work, or in-work poverty). They also clearly distinguished between ‘carrots’ (making work pay) and ‘sticks’ (sanctions) and used comparative evidence. Weaker answers failed to comprehensively address the question, lacked a coherent argument and/or contained mistakes.

Question 11: Origins of welfare state

The best answers clearly addressed the question and demonstrated knowledge of the ideological, political, and economic factors that led to the emergence of the British welfare state and their relation to the nation state. The weakest answer failed to comprehensively address the question due to a lack of focus on the nation state, lacked a coherent argument and/or demonstrated poor knowledge of theoretical perspectives explaining the emergence of the British welfare state.

Question 12: Child poverty

This was the most popular question (16 % of answers). The best answers demonstrated breadth of knowledge of policy developments under successive UK government in several areas such as family, education, social assistance, and labour market policy affecting the economic situation of children. They also critically appraised the notion of opportunity and distinguished between different concepts of poverty (e.g., absolute versus relative, narrow versus broad, opportunities versus outcomes). The weakest answers demonstrated a limited knowledge of measures affecting child poverty, focused only on one or two areas of policies, and failed to link those measures to ideas of opportunity, aspiration and stability as outlined in the question.

225 Comparative Demographic Systems

To follow.

227 Politics of China

General Comments: This year, we had a total of twenty-two students sitting the exam, which included students reading PPE as well as History and Politics. The range of preparation and experience among the students sitting the exam was reflected in final marks, which had a fairly expected distribution. Most candidates opted to answer a combination of questions that covered different elements of the course. Successful responses demonstrated a good balance of factual knowledge, critical analysis and understanding of relevant issues; the most successful answers and scripts provided excellent depth of engagement with specific scholarly literature (in terms of both concepts and arguments). Scripts that received lower marks either provided answers that were too brief, poorly organised, lacked a critical or analytical focus, or did not demonstrate a familiarity with the relevant scholarly literature/assigned readings on a given topic.

Comments on individual questions: The most popular questions for candidates tended to be either those that called for either an evaluation of a historic or contemporary process in PRC politics, or those that addressed a clearly delineated debate within the subfield. Popular topics included the timing and sequencing of economic reform and its relationship to democratization; rule of law; political representation; and whether authoritarian responsiveness served to increase or reduce popular contention. Less popular topics included questions on the first decade of PRC rule, the Cultural Revolution, gender equality, and anything that referred directly to Xi Jinping. Candidates also tended to steer clear of questions on the Belt-and-Road Initiative and the politically sensitive question of whether the “One Country, Two Systems” framework can still be said to exist in Hong Kong, although a few of those that dared to tackle the less popular questions furnished answers that merited top marks.

228 Politics of the EU

Seven (all PPE student) students sat this paper in June 2021. The students did very well, five exams reached an overall mark above 70 (highest mark 75), two exams were above 60 (upper second). The mean was 70.57 in 2021 (compared to 66.1 in 2020). This result is slightly higher compared to the 2020 exam, but the number of exams awarded first class is similar to the 2019 exam when four out of eight exams reached a grade above 70. The excellent results are in line with the results PPE students achieved in the 2019 exam when the average mark of PPE students was 74.4.

The distribution of answers was as follows:

Question	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
number of answers	2	2	1		2	2	1	3	1	1	3	3

Students had to answer 3 out of 12 essay questions, and the distribution of chosen questions ensured that students had to draw on diverse set of topics that had been covered throughout the course. In a similar trend to last year when students tended to choose the more political and conceptual questions, again this year students picked the more complex issue questions over the questions that are more focused on institutional design.

Question 8 (Common Foreign and Security Policy – 3 x answered), Q11 (the EU in crisis – 3 x answered) and Q12 (differentiated integration – 3 x answered) were the most popular questions followed by Q1 (theories of European integration – intergovernmentalism – 2 x answered), Q2(theories of European integration - neo-functionalism – 2 x answered), Q5 (European Commission – 2 x answered) and Q6 (EU's democratic deficit - 2 x answered). Q3 (European Council) Q7 (EU enlargement) and Q10 (market power Europe) received one answer. The only question that was not chosen by students was Q4 (impact of Treaty of Lisbon on EU governance). The strong engagement with a diverse set of topics shows that students have developed a broad range of interests. In addition to discussing recent political challenges such as EU foreign and security policy and the impact of the recent crisis, students have also reflected on theoretical debates and evaluated the explanatory power of different theoretical approaches. The level of engagement with the academic literature and empirical sources is of a very high standard.

Exams above 60 were able to present their argument in a coherent and correct fashion but were more limited in scope and lacked wider political considerations and critical reflection. Exams above 65 had to showcase the ability of independent analysis, even if with missing aspects or few shortcomings. One exam (final mark 68) was very well done and showcased the ability of an independent argument but just missed still the holistic critical approach that would be expected from a first. The five essays marked 70 and above needed to go beyond what had been covered in the lectures, go beyond textbook chapters and had to display a critical engagement with the wider academic scholarship. They showcased excellent factual knowledge about a wider variety of different aspects, a sound line of analytical argumentation, with a convincing critical reflection.

229 Advanced Paper in Theories of Justice

21 candidates sat this paper, and both markers agreed that the quality of answers was generally very good. Overall, 6 candidates gained overall marks of 70 or above, 14 gained overall marks between 60 and 69, and 1 an overall mark of below 60. All questions which were clearly linked to specific syllabus topics received at least 4 answers, including the relatively new topic on UBI, with the exception of the relatively new topic on justice and healthcare, which received just a solitary response. The more generic questions towards the end of the paper were, perhaps unsurprisingly, rather less popular. Candidates showed good knowledge of relevant literature across all topics, although, as in previous years, there was a tendency in some answers to rely a little too heavily on both the content and the format of lectures given on particular topics.

Comments for individual questions are provided when there were multiple respondents.

1. **Does justice in trade require that gains from trading be shared equally amongst participants? (4 responses)**

This question was the least popular among the questions clearly linked to specific topics, but was notably well answered, with 3 of the responses gaining a mark of 70 or above. Essays generally picked up and made good use of the necessary / sufficient distinction in the question.

2. **Does a state's right to self-determination mean that it is entitled to control who enters its territory? (6 responses)**

Slightly variable responses to this question, some of which needed to do more to focus specifically on self-determination rather than the general question of whether there is a right to exclude.

3. **'Duties to address historic injustice are grounded in the interests of the living, not the dead.' Discuss. (11 responses)**

This was (marginally) the most popular question, and received some strong responses, with 4 essays of 70 or above, which notably demonstrated good knowledge of relevant literature and were able to give a coherent account of what it would mean for a duty to address historic injustice to be grounded in the interests of people who are no longer alive (whether or not this idea was thought to be plausible).

4. **According to what principles should the future greenhouse gas emissions of different states be decided? (10 responses)**

Again, there was quite a range in the quality of answers to this question, with two essays of 70 or above, 6 in the 60-69 range, and 2 which received lower marks. Stronger answers were able to focus on the question of future GHG emissions specifically, with, for example, some good discussion of grandfathering, less strong answers were more generic in their treatment of the allocation of the costs of climate change, possibly relying too much on tutorial essays.

5. **Should egalitarians be concerned about inequality between present generations and future generations? (5 responses)**

Again, some variable quality here (one essay above 70, 2 in the 60-69 range and 2 below this range). Some answers did struggle to focus on equality specifically, and instead raised more general issues of intergenerational justice.

6. **'A fair consideration of the well-being of people with disabilities would necessitate radical social reform.' Discuss. (10 responses)**

A popular question, which prompted a couple of outstanding answers showing exceptional knowledge of relevant literature. Less successful answers used the question as a prompt for a standard social / medical model essay.

7. **Does justice require that all persons have the same access to healthcare? (1 response)**

8. **Should feminists support the introduction of universal basic income policies? (6 responses)**

Some answers here showed knowledge of specific literature on feminism and UBI, which was unsurprisingly helpful, but even those candidates who did not seem familiar with this work were able to apply other writing to the question in a plausible fashion.

9. **To what extent should we take account of the interests of parents when considering the rights of children? (8 responses)**

Generally done well, with some interesting discussion of, for example, recent work on the "best available parent" view.

10. **'Corporations can possess duties of justice in the same manner as states.' Discuss. (0 responses)**

11. **To what extent do persons have individual duties to seek to mitigate structural injustice? (1 response)**

12. **'If we seek to affect public policy in the real world, we should avoid appeals to controversial principles of distributive justice.' Discuss. (0 responses)**

230 Comparative Political Economy

35 students wrote the 230: Comparative Political Economy exam. This exam was the first since 2019 to use a closed book format, which meant that the length and depth of answers differed from the previous two years. The general quality of the exam was high. As in previous years, stronger answers honed in on the core of what the question was asking, interrogated its assumptions, and drew on a wide variety of readings. As usual, the question on equity and efficiency and the welfare state were both very popular. Many responses however, did directly address what these questions were asking, and did not engage directly with the prompt. This problem was particularly the case for the question on the welfare state, which raised a theoretical debate over the measurement and understanding of social policy. Better answers both carefully defined the core terms, and made clear their interpretation of the question. The question on VoC, globalization, economic voting and inequality were generally well answered. The questions on the knowledge economy and institutional change were less popular, but also well answered.

297 Special Subject in Politics: Feminist Theory

A total of 28 candidates sat the Feminist Theory exam in Philosophy. A total of 19 candidates sat the (qualitatively identical) Feminist Theory exam in Politics.

The overall performance was markedly strong, with over one-third of candidates achieving a mark of 70 or higher across both Philosophy and Politics. The distribution of marks across Philosophy and Politics was very similar.

Most essays displayed a lively interest in the subject, a close engagement with the readings, and an appreciation of the overall dialectic. They also generally made an effort to advance a clear line of argument, even while paying due attention to complexity and nuance.

The very best essays impressed with their command of the texts – including, in some cases, texts not found on the reading list – with some candidates offering short quotations of key texts, including date citations. The best essays also demonstrated a deft handling of argumentative complexity, the ability to say something original about well-worn topics, and an awareness of feminist history. They also paid attention to the specificity of the questions posed, rather than just taking the questions as an occasion to rehearse familiar arguments.

By contrast, the least successful essays often avoided the question posed in favour of a more general commentary on the topic. They also lacked tight analysis, preferring generalities over specifics; sometimes this was accompanied by an editorial style, in which candidates asserted broad (often normative) conclusions without adequate defence. Weaker essays also tended towards 'listiness', offering a series of comments and claims without any overall structure. While such essays often demonstrated an admirable acquaintance with a wide range of readings, they fell short of the highest marks because they did not advance a clear line of argument. Some weaker essays also neglected to engage with relevant readings, preferring to draw solely or largely on resources from other papers.

All questions were attempted by at least one Politics candidate except for Q3 (on sex discrimination), Q4 (on queering feminism), Q13 (on feminist metaphysis) and Q14 (on choice). The most popular questions among Politics candidates were Q1 (on 'women'), Q6 (on sex work), Q7 (on capitalism) and Q16 (on sexual desire).

All questions were attempted by at least one Philosophy candidate except for Q5 (on the 'human'), Q9 (on reproduction) and Q12 (on autonomy). The most popular questions among Philosophy candidates were Q1 (on 'women'), Q6 (on sex work), Q8 (on pornography) and Q16 (on sexual desire).

Q6 – the most popular question among both Philosophy and Politics candidates – asked candidates to assess the following argument: ''The problem with the slogan "Sex work is work" is that it ignores the moral specialness of sex.' Weaker answers tended to avoid the question, rehearsing arguments about the morality of sex *work* rather than the (putative) moral specialness of *sex* per se. The best answers canvassed a wide range of reasons for thinking that sex might be morally special, and then thought carefully about how this (putative) moral specialness might bear on the question of whether this was a problem for the slogan 'Sex work is work'. The examiners were impressed by those candidates who recognised that this latter question requires us to grapple with the political function of slogans.

Q1 asked candidates to discuss the following quotation from Lola Olufemi: ““Women” . . . is an umbrella under which we gather in order to make political demands.’ Most candidates were able to discern that the claim, despite its descriptive appearance, is in fact normative: Olufemi is claiming that feminists should see ‘women’ simply as a pragmatically useful banner under which to gather, not as a term that picks out a natural or otherwise cohesive group. The best essays on this question offered reasons for thinking that this was right, or wrong, drawing on arguments from e.g. Crenshaw, Spelman, Zack and Butler. Weaker answers used the question as an occasion to rehearse rival views of gender, often not clearly distinguishing between views that aim to disclose the real nature (however constructed) of gender, and those (like Olufemi’s) that aim to offer practical advice on the concept’s political usefulness or not.

Q16 invited candidates to discuss what we should do about sexual desires that appear to be morally problematic. The best essays forthrightly engaged the question by thinking about whether sexual desires could indeed be morally problematic – and, if so, in what way. They distinguished between desires for apparently morally problematic *objects* (e.g. paedophilia) and acts (e.g. rape fantasies), those desires shaped by systems of unjust domination (e.g. sexual racism), and so on. They queried who the ‘we’ in the question might be, and drew distinctions between addressing our *own* desires and those of others. They also laid out the worries with advancing political critiques of desires, drawing on close readings of Bartky, Zheng, Srinivasan and others. Weaker essays on this question covered relevant ground in a more ‘listy’ fashion, and often asserted normative judgments (that e.g. sexual racism is bad) without making a case for it.

Q7, which asked whether capitalism needs patriarchy, was the third most popular question among Politics candidates, and the sixth among Philosophy candidates. This question drew out some of the very most impressive essays across the examination. The best answers distinguished between a weak and strong interpretation of the question: whether capitalism as it currently exists, or in nearby possible worlds, requires patriarchy; and whether capitalism as such, or in all possible worlds, requires patriarchy. The best essays marshalled resources from Marx and Engels, the Wages for Housework feminists, Angela Davis and Nancy Fraser in tackling the question, and did so with an impressive command of the subtleties of difficult texts. The very best essays also addressed the changing face of contemporary capitalism and its relationship to questions of gender, demonstrating an admirable historical sensibility.

Q8 was the third most popular question among Philosophy candidates, and the seventh among Politics candidates. It asked candidates to discuss the following quotation from Nancy Bauer: ‘‘There is nothing . . . to *be* authorized [by pornography]: the idea that women are essentially sexual objects for men, along with the idea that the happiest and most womanly women embrace this status, is ubiquitously accepted in our culture.’ Unlike the Olufemi quotation in Q1, the Bauer quotation is from a text on the paper’s reading list. As such, the examiners would have expected candidates to demonstrate a familiarity with Bauer’s argument in their answers. In fact, very few candidates were able to speak to Bauer’s broader argument, leading occasionally to some odd elaborations of the quotation – for example, some candidates presumed that Bauer thinks that the happiest women do indeed embrace their sexual objecthood. The better essays on this question recognised, and explained, the importance of authority to the ‘porn debate’, situating that notion within Langton’s speech act account of pornography’s power. Even so, some of these essays countered Bauer’s claim – that porn doesn’t have the requisite authority to perform the illocutionary speech acts that

Langton ascribes to it – by re-asserting, without argument, pornography's authority. The very best essays took efforts to argue either for or against porn's authority, producing an impressive engagement with Bauer's quotation and overall argument.

297 International Security and Conflict

We had 50 (1 student withdrew, hence 49 marked scripts) students taking the public exam for the International Security and Conflict paper, the average mark for the paper was a 66,9 (lowest 58, highest 77). Last year there was a decision by the exam committee to change the overall distribution of the mark, as I wrote in my past report I was - as convenor of the paper - not in favour about this because I believe it led to unfairness against a well organised paper and very committed students. Hence, I hope this year the agreed marks by the two markers could be accepted as they are without unnecessary and artificially marks' distribution harmonisations.

This is a "Special Subject in Politics" paper, but it is becoming extremely popular and students who pick this paper are very committed and the quality of their answers is very high. Notice that our syllabus has clearly stated required readings and we also provide a set of revisions classes to prepare students for the exam.

All questions but question 10 were answered, however there is an important variation between question. See next table.

ISC_question_number	Freq.	Percent	Cum.
3	1	0.68	0.68
8	9	6.12	6.80
11	11	7.48	14.29
12	15	10.20	24.49
6	16	10.88	35.37
1	12	8.16	43.54
7	17	11.56	55.10
2	18	12.24	67.35
9	20	13.61	80.95
5	15	10.20	91.16
4	13	8.84	100.00
Total	147	100.00	

The most three popular questions were 9 (sexual violence in civil wars, 20 answers), 2 (on interstate-war, 18 answers), 7 (on mass atrocities, 17 answers). However, notices that also 5 (on nuclear deterrence), 12 (on peace operations) and 6 (on terrorism) were very popular. The question on NATO (Q3) was answered only once and the questions on non-violent movements (Q10) did not receive any answer. We could think to introduce a week on "climate change and conflict" instead of transnational non-violent movements.

It should be noticed that the variation of marks - most above 2.1 - is quite low between questions. Hence, most of the answers were very good regardless of what question was answered.

The exam questions follow. I highlight some key-points that characterized strong/excellent answers. Of course the necessary, but not sufficient, conditions to elaborate a strong answer were defining core concepts and using the relevant compulsory reading.

1. **Is international security just a function of national interest?**

Excellent answers provided alternative definitions of security we reviewed during the lecture and tutorials. They also critically evaluate what it was meant for "function of national interest" and some of the best ones showed how the role of national interest changed over time and depended on the role of a country in global politics.

2. **Does high uncertainty lead to higher or lower risk of inter-state war outbreak?**

The starting point was defining what we mean for uncertainty and why it should matter. Then engaging with bargain models (Fearon), misperception (Jervis), overconfidence (Johnson) and few engages with Gartzke.

3. **"What we are currently experiencing is the brain death of NATO." Discuss.**

Only one answer. This is a quote from Macron, hence it would have been excellent to compare how NATO and members have changed their attitude also after the Russian invasion of Ukraine. Piece by Mejer (IS) would have been an asset but also book on regions and power by Waever and Buzan.

4. **If we will resolve horizontal inequalities, will civil wars disappear?**

Best answers first defined term and discussed relevant literature on horizontal inequalities (Gurr, but also Cederman et al). They also critically discussed whether causes were not just material but also about ideologies, norms of subjections and political power seeking.

5. **"Ukraine should have been quietly encouraged to fashion its own nuclear deterrent. Even now, pressing Ukraine to become a nonnuclear state is a mistake". J. Mearsheimer. Was the author, who wrote this in 1993, wrong?**

Several good answers. First introduced the concept of nuclear deterrence and discussed the recent development in Europe. But also discussed how nuclear deterrence does not directly resolved proxy wars and challenge the "nuclear peace" arguments by Schelling but also Nuno Monteiro and Målfrid Braut- Hegghammer.

6. **Is terrorism the weapon of the weak?**

Best answers discussed issues on what means "weak", military or in terms of strategies or outcomes. Use required readings to provided empirical context and use recent literature on strategies (for instance Polo and Gleditsch).

7. **What is the relation between war and mass atrocities?**

Use of empirical literature that show correlation between the two phenomena, but then using Straus (or other more recent literature) critically evaluating under what conditions mass atrocities happen in war.

8. Can displaced people be actors of violence?

Excellent answers organised the essay between direct and indirect using the core readings but using also very recent readings from journals such as International Organization and World Politics. Then, discussed the concept of "more important", they evaluated and compared cases using empirics from, for example, UNHCR and case studies.

9. Can sexual violence variation in civil wars be explained strategically? How?

First discussion on possible absence of strategy, then first and second order strategy use. Second elaborated mechanisms about recruitment, group's cohesion, and socialization (Wood and Cohen).

11. Can cyberwarfare challenge the survival of a country?

First discussion how cyberwarfare can challenge the survival of a country (and what is the meaning of survival), then from the work of Kello elaboration of challenges and issues of deterrence theory related to cyberwarfare. Use of Nye and Gartzke also to counterbalance the "size of the revolution".

12. Would you advise your government to invest more in UN peace operations?

Students first highlight how peace operations could resolve commitments problems and informative issues (e.g. Hultman et al.), but then moved beyond it and used for instance Lise Howard 's persuasion argument and the role of local peacekeepers (e.g. Autesserre; Campbell). Discuss how the "investments" depend on normative bases but also legitimacy seeking behaviour of states.